

AFTER EFFECTS · BUILD-ALONG SYSTEM

Think Like an Agency

The Agency-Grade Explainer Playbook

*Conceive → Script → **Build** → Animate.*

*The complete system for designing 18 portfolio-winning SaaS
explainers, and any product you'll ever be handed.*

LULU

Motion Direction & Editorial Craft

PERSONAL EDITION
2026



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AFTER EFFECTS · BUILD-ALONG SYSTEM

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The Agency-Grade Explainer Playbook

Conceive → Script → Build → Animate, a complete, reusable system for conceiving, scripting, building, and animating any SaaS explainer video, demonstrated end-to-end across eighteen named brands.



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THE ONE TEST

*“Can someone understand this scene
muted, at 1.5× speed?”*

If not, simplify. Nothing in this book gets animated until the animatic passes that test. Every chapter answers to it.

BEFORE PART I

How to use this book

This is one system, applied eighteen times, not eighteen separate tutorials. The frameworks and the element library you build in Part II are reusable; you construct each element once and redeploy it across every video.

The book is built so that a reader with no named brand can make agency-grade work from Part I alone, and a reader with a client meeting tomorrow can jump straight to the relevant brand study or codex entry. The litmus test that governs every decision in these pages is printed opposite, and every scene in the book is held to it: **"Can someone understand this scene muted, at 1.5× speed?"** If not, simplify. Nothing gets animated until the animatic passes that test.

Three reading paths

The linear learner. Read it in order. Part I sets the universal system; Part II builds the reusable element library; Part III applies the whole stack to eighteen recognizable brands; Part IV proves the method on a product that doesn't exist yet; Part V ships and sells the work. By the last page you will have exercised every technique in the codex against a real, nameable brand.

The reference lookup. Treat Part II as a manual. Each codex entry is self-contained, BUILD IT, ANIMATE IT, when to use it, which brands want it, a pitfall, a pro move, and a variation, and the Expression Library in Appendix A collects every line of code in one place.

"I have a client tomorrow." Open Chapter 2 to derive the single message, skim the matching brand study in Part III for the technique cluster, and use the templates in Appendix F to storyboard tonight. The QA rubric in Chapter 40 is your pre-delivery checklist.

⊖ THE ONE RULE, STATED ONCE

Every chapter answers to a single test. A scene that cannot be understood with the sound off, at one-and-a-half times speed, has failed, no matter how polished the keyframes. Most feeds autoplay muted; design for that, and sound-on becomes a bonus rather than a crutch. This book returns to that sentence at the end of every technique, every brand, and every assembly.

ORIENTATION

Read Part I once, keep Part II open while you build, work Part III brand by brand, and let the litmus test arbitrate every judgment call in between.

BEFORE PART I

Notation & conventions

A few conventions recur throughout. Reading them once here saves a footnote on every page.

CONVENTION	MEANS
ease 80/20	Keyframe velocity at 80% influence outgoing / 20% incoming in the Graph Editor, the house “snap out, soft land.” The single most important default in the book.
Easy Ease (F9)	After Effects’ built-in smooth-in/smooth-out applied to selected keyframes.
frames, not seconds	Durations are given in frames at 30 fps unless noted. 15 frames = 0.5 s; 12 frames is the house card-entrance length.
Brand Controls	A null object holding one Color Control per brand color; every fill references it, so one change recolors the whole video (Chapter 7).
§ cross-references	A section mark points to another chapter or codex entry, e.g. “the traveling pulse (§13.4).”
monospace	Anything in <code>this face</code> is a literal AE menu path, layer name, effect, or expression you can type verbatim.
the litmus mark ☹	Flags the muted-at-1.5× test wherever a scene must be checked against it.

The seven callout boxes

Every technique in Part II, and every brand in Part III, is organised with the same seven recurring callouts, so you always know where to look:

► **BUILD IT**, how to construct the element from scratch in AE.

● **ANIMATE IT**, the keyframes, eases, and timing that bring it alive.

⚠ **PITFALL**, the amateur version, and why it fails.

★ **PRO MOVE**, the agency-grade upgrade most people miss.

◆ **BRAND NOTE**, how the move shifts per brand temperature.

✓ **CHECKLIST**, the end-of-section pass/fail.

☹ **LITMUS**, the muted-1.5× check for that specific move.

ONE PAGE, THEN NEVER AGAIN

These conventions hold for the whole book; from here on they are used without re-explanation.

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Every part, chapter, and major section, each with a one-line scope note.



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PART I

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THE WHOLE SHAPE

Nine foundation chapters, a seven-chapter codex, all eighteen brands in full, an invented-SaaS proof, a ship-and-sell part, and six appendices, the complete arc.



PART I

Foundations

The universal, brand-agnostic system. Strategy, script, pre-viz, voice, sound, brand, and the motion rulebook, a reader with no named brand can make agency-grade work from Part I alone.



IN THIS PART

- 1 The Agency-Grade Mindset
- 2 Pre-Production & Strategy
- 3 Script & Story Structure
- 4 Visual Planning
- 5 Voiceover & Narration
- 6 Audio Design & Beat-Syncing
- 7 Art Direction & the Brand Kit
- 8 Motion Design Principles
- 9 Project Setup & Reusable Systems



PART I • FOUNDATIONS

1 The Agency-Grade Mindset

What actually separates agency work from tutorial output is not a plugin or a budget. It is a single test, applied without mercy, before a frame is animated.

SECTIONS

- 1.1 The gap nobody names
- 1.2 The muted-1.5× litmus
- 1.3 System over tutorial
- 1.4 Build once, redeploy eighteen times

1.1 The gap nobody names

Watch a hundred SaaS explainers and they sort cleanly into two piles. One pile is competent: the UI is on screen, the voiceover is clear, the logo lands. The other pile feels *expensive*, the eye always knows where to look, the cuts breathe with the music, and you understand the product before the narrator finishes the sentence. The difference is almost never the tooling. It is a set of disciplines applied so consistently that they read as a house style.

This book names those disciplines and makes them repeatable. The thesis is simple: agency work is a **system applied with restraint**, not a bag of effects applied with enthusiasm. Everything in Parts I-II exists to make that system inheritable, so that by Part III each of eighteen videos becomes assembly rather than invention.

⚠ PITFALL

The tutorial reflex is to reach for an effect to solve a feeling, a glow here, a particle system there. Effects are the last 10% of craft. The first 90% is scale, opacity, and position with good easing, one idea per frame, and ruthless cutting. If a scene feels flat, the fix is almost always timing or hierarchy, not a new effect.

1.2 The muted-1.5× litmus

One sentence governs every decision in this book: “**Can someone understand this scene muted, at 1.5× speed?**” Most feeds autoplay with the sound off, and viewers scrub. If your story only works with narration at full speed, it does not work. Design for the harshest realistic viewing condition and the comfortable one takes care of itself.

🕒 LITMUS

Run it on every scene, not just the finished cut. Mute the comp, play it at 1.5×, and ask a colleague who has never seen it: *what just happened, and why does it matter?* If they hesitate, the frame has too much, the focal point is weak, or the idea is moving too slowly. Fix the cut, not the keyframes.

Why speed, specifically

Running at 1.5× exposes two faults that real-time playback hides: dead beats (a shot that sits too long with no new information) and reveals that depend on the viewer reading small text. At speed, only strong hierarchy and clear motion survive, which is exactly the bar a scrolling feed sets.

1.3 System over tutorial

A tutorial teaches you to make one thing. A system teaches you to make the next thing faster than the last. The whole architecture of this book is a system: a strategy you can run on any product (Chapter 2), a story skeleton that fits any pitch (Chapter 3), a pre-viz gate that fails cheaply (Chapter 4), and a parametrized element library (Part II) that you build once and recolor per brand.

1.4 Build once, redeploy eighteen times

The payoff arrives in Part III. Because the eighteen brands were chosen to force *different* technique clusters, Stripe's connection-line flow, Duolingo's character squash, Headspace's drift, finishing all eighteen means you have exercised the entire codex against a real, nameable brand. Each new video reuses pre-comps from the last, retimed and recolored through a single Brand Controls null. That inheritance is the difference between a portfolio that took a year and one that took a month.

TAKEAWAY

Agency-grade is a discipline, not a budget: one idea per frame, consistent easing, ruthless cutting, and a single governing test, can a stranger follow it muted, at 1.5×?



PART I · FOUNDATIONS

2 Pre-Production & Strategy

Before any frame, lock four things per product: who is buying, the one-sentence value prop, the single message the video must land, and how the angle shifts for the other audience. The single message is the constraint that kills scope creep.

SECTIONS

- 2.1 The four locks
- 2.2 Deriving the single message
- 2.3 The B2B/B2C angle shift
- 2.4 The strategy table, all eighteen

2.1 The four locks

Pre-production is four decisions, written down before After Effects opens. Skip them and every later choice becomes an argument; make them and every later choice becomes a yes/no question against the message.

► BUILD IT, THE FOUR LOCKS

1. **Who's buying.** B2B, B2C, or both, and which one this cut is for. A video cannot serve two buyers equally; pick the primary.
2. **The value prop, in one sentence.** If it needs two sentences, you have two products or a fuzzy one.
3. **THE single message.** The one thing a viewer must remember. It fits on a sticky note. Everything that does not serve it gets cut.
4. **The angle shift.** How the hook, proof, and CTA change if you repositioned this for the other audience, same brand kit, different doorway.

2.2 Deriving the single message

The single message is not the tagline and not the feature list. It is the emotional claim the product earns. For Stripe it is “money movement, solved with a few lines of code.” For Notion, “replace five tools with one canvas you shape yourself.” Notice the shape: a tension the buyer feels, resolved by the product, in the buyer's language, not the company's.

★ PRO MOVE

Write the single message as the sentence a happy customer would say to a skeptical friend, not the sentence the marketing site says. “It does the hard thinking with you, not for you” (Claude) is something a person says; “an AI assistant powered by advanced reasoning” is something a homepage says. The first one animates; the second one doesn't.

2.3 The B2B/B2C angle shift

The footage and elements stay the same; the **hook, the proof, and the CTA** change. A Stripe dev video opens on a code editor and ends with “read the docs”; the finance version opens on a revenue chart and ends with “see your numbers.” Same brand kit, different doorway. Knowing the shift up front means you can shoot one set of assets and cut two videos.

2.4 The strategy table, all eighteen

The complete pre-production grid for the eighteen, abbreviated to message and angle. Full brand kits arrive in Chapter 7; full scripts in Chapter 3.

PRODUCT	BUYER	THE SINGLE MESSAGE	ANGLE SHIFT FOR THE OTHER AUDIENCE
Claude	B2C + B2B	It does the hard thinking <i>with</i> you, not <i>for</i> you.	B2C: creativity /

PRODUCT	BUYER	THE SINGLE MESSAGE	ANGLE SHIFT FOR THE OTHER AUDIENCE
			everyday tasks → B2B: a secure, capable teammate that scales knowledge work.
Stripe	B2B (devs + finance)	Money movement, solved with a few lines of code.	Dev angle: clean API → Finance angle: unified revenue dashboard & reporting.
Notion	B2C + B2B	Replace five tools with one canvas you shape yourself.	B2C: personal life OS → B2B: team wiki + project hub, single source of truth.
Figma	B2B (design/product)	Design as a team sport, everyone in the same file.	IC designer: powerful editor → Org: design-system governance at scale.
Slack	B2B	Your team's work happens in channels, not buried in inboxes.	SMB: simple chat → Enterprise: integrated workflow hub with automation.
Linear	B2B (eng teams)	Software planning that feels as fast as you think.	IC dev: keyboard-fast → Eng leader: roadmap clarity and velocity insight.
Spotify	B2C	The soundtrack to your day, already knows what's next.	Listener: discovery / vibe → Spotify for Artists:

PRODUCT	BUYER	THE SINGLE MESSAGE	ANGLE SHIFT FOR THE OTHER AUDIENCE
			reach and royalty insight.
Canva	B2C + B2B (SMB)	Anyone can make it look designed.	Solo creator: speed / templates → Teams: brand kit + on-brand at scale.
Loom	B2B	Say it once on video instead of a meeting that didn't need to happen.	IC: quick share → Org: async culture, fewer meetings, faster onboarding.
Airtable	B2B	Your data, shaped into any view your team needs.	Builder: flexible base → Ops leader: connected apps and workflows.
Duolingo	B2C	Tiny daily wins make a new language stick.	Learner: fun / streaks → Schools: measurable progress.
Grammarly	B2C + B2B	Sound clear and confident in every message.	Individual: fewer mistakes → Org: consistent, on-brand, secure comms.
Calendly	B2B + prosumer	Share a link, skip the 'does Tuesday work?' thread.	Solo: easy booking → Teams: routing, round-robin, CRM-connected pipelines.
Webflow	B2B (design/marketing)	Design it visually, ship production-grade code.	Designer: creative control → Marketing

PRODUCT	BUYER	THE SINGLE MESSAGE	ANGLE SHIFT FOR THE OTHER AUDIENCE
			team: launch and edit without devs.
Miro	B2B	Every idea, on one endless canvas the whole team can see.	Facilitator: workshops → Org: persistent visual collaboration across teams.
Robinhood	B2C	Investing that fits in your pocket, no jargon required.	Beginner: simplicity → Active user: data, options, retirement tools.
Headspace	B2C + B2B (benefits)	A few minutes to feel less stressed today.	Individual: calm / sleep → Employer: workforce wellbeing & lower burnout.
HubSpot	B2B	Stop stitching tools together, grow on one connected platform.	SMB: free CRM start → Enterprise: full revenue platform with attribution.

TAKEAWAY

One sentence, one message, one buyer per cut, written down before you open AE. Then every later decision is a yes/no question against the message, and scope creep has nowhere to hide.

✓ **CHECKLIST**

- ✓ Buyer named (and the primary one chosen for this cut)
- ✓ Value prop fits one sentence
- ✓ Single message fits on a sticky note
- ✓ Alternate-audience angle noted (hook / proof / CTA)
- ✓ Anything not serving the message is already cut



PART I · FOUNDATIONS

3 Script & Story Structure

The script is the spine; every visual hangs off a specific line. A seven-beat skeleton, written for the ear, budgeted at roughly two-and-a-half words per second, fits any product into forty-five to ninety seconds.

SECTIONS

- 3.1 The seven-beat skeleton
- 3.2 Writing for the ear
- 3.3 Word-budgeting by duration
- 3.4 Worked scripts

3.1 The seven-beat skeleton

Every script in this book is the same skeleton, retimed. Total target 45-90 s; at a natural pace of ~2.5 words/second, a 60 s video is ~150 spoken words.

BEAT	PURPOSE	DURATION	WORDS	DO	DON'T
Hook	Stop the scroll; name the tension	0-5s	8-15	Lead with pain or a surprising claim	Open with "Introducing..." or a logo
Problem	Make the old way hurt	5-15s	15-25	Show the messy status quo	List features; over-explain
Solution	Reveal the product as the turn	15-25s	12-20	One clean reveal tied to the brand	Reveal three things at once
Walkthrough	Show it working	25-55s	35-60	Real UI, one action per shot	Tour every menu
Benefits	Translate features to outcomes	55-70s	20-30	"So you can..." language	Repeat the feature
Proof (opt.)	Borrow credibility	70-78s	8-15	One stat or one logo wall, fast	Cram five logos
CTA	The next step	78-90s	6-12	One verb, one destination	Multiple CTAs; tiny URL

3.2 Writing for the ear

► BUILD IT, THE FOUR WRITING RULES

1. Write for the **ear**, not the page, contractions, short clauses, one idea per sentence.
2. The **first three seconds** carry the whole video. Weak hook, nobody sees the CTA.
3. **Cut every word the visual already says.** If the screen shows a drag-and-drop, don't narrate "you drag and drop."
4. End on a **single** action verb.

⚠ PITFALL

The most common script failure is narrating the screen. The visual and the voice should carry *different* halves of the meaning, the screen shows the action, the VO says why it matters. Redundancy between them wastes the scarcest resource you have: seconds.

3.3 Word-budgeting by duration

At ~2.5 words/second, multiply your target seconds by 2.5 to get your word ceiling, then write under it. A 60 s master is ~150 words; an 80 s flagship (Stripe) is ~165 words spread over a longer walkthrough. Calm brands (Claude, Headspace) drop to ~2.0 words/second and budget fewer words for the same runtime, the silence is part of the brand.

3.4 Worked scripts

Every one of the eighteen ships with a complete, timed, production-ready script in its brand study (Part III), formatted as [Beat | mm:ss] lines. Two representative openings show the range, the same skeleton, different temperature:

Stripe, confident: “Accepting payments used to take a team and three months.”

Headspace, calm: “Take a breath. No, really, one slow breath.”

Both name a tension in under four seconds. Neither says “introducing.” The full scripts, with every beat timed, live in Chapters 17–34.

TAKEAWAY

Lock the script before you storyboard, it is the spine, and every visual hangs off a specific line. If a beat can’t earn its seconds out loud, it won’t earn them on screen.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Hook lands the tension in 3 seconds
- ✓ Problem shown before solution
- ✓ One idea per sentence; written for the ear
- ✓ Word count fits duration at ~2.5 w/s
- ✓ Single closing verb
- ✓ Visual never narrates itself



PART I • FOUNDATIONS

4 Visual Planning

Nothing gets animated until the animatic feels right muted at 1.5×. Mood board → style frames → storyboard → asset list → animatic is the gate. Skipping it is the single biggest reason explainers look amateur.

SECTIONS

- 4.1 Mood board
- 4.2 Style frames
- 4.3 Storyboard template
- 4.4 Asset list
- 4.5 The animatic gate

You discover a pacing problem either in an afternoon of pre-viz or after two days of animating. Pre-production is choosing the afternoon.

4.1 Mood board

Decide look, motion style, and tone before you commit. Build it in Figma or Milanote with three columns per product:

1. **Look references**, 6-10 stills: real product screenshots, the brand's marketing site, and 2-3 aspirational frames from agency reels (Stripe Sessions, Apple product films, Linear launches).
2. **Motion references**, 3-4 videos, each annotated with the *specific* technique you're borrowing: "Stripe's connection-line draw-on," "Linear's snap-cut on Cmd-K," "Headspace's slow gradient drift."
3. **Tone words**, pick exactly three (Stripe = precise, confident, effortless; Headspace = soft, unhurried, warm). These three words arbitrate every later judgment call.

★ PRO MOVE

Pull the real hex codes and fonts (Chapter 7) onto the mood board now, so it is already on-brand rather than a generic "blue tech" vibe. A mood board in the actual brand palette catches tone problems a placeholder never will.

4.2 Style frames

Two or three fully-rendered hero frames at *final quality*, to get the look approved before any motion exists. Per video, design three:

- **The hero / solution moment**, the product reveal; the frame you'd put on a poster.
- **A walkthrough frame**, UI in context with a callout or two; proves the busiest moment reads cleanly.
- **The end card / CTA lockup**, logo, tagline, brand background.

⊖ LITMUS

Export the style frames at 1920×1080 and view them at 50% zoom on a phone. If the hierarchy survives that, the look is approved. Do not proceed to storyboard until the frames are signed off, this is where you catch "the gradient bands" or "the text is too small" for free.

4.3 Storyboard template

A frame-by-frame board for every shot. This exact table doubles as your shot list and converts directly into the shot-by-shot timeline (Part III).

SHOT	FRAME SKETCH / LAYOUT	FRAMING & COMPOSITION	ON SCREEN (ELEMENTS)	CONNECTS TO NEXT VIA
S1	rough thumbnail or one-line layout	centered, lots of negative space	what's literally visible	the transition logic

SHOT	FRAME SKETCH / LAYOUT	FRAMING & COMPOSITION	ON SCREEN (ELEMENTS)	CONNECTS TO NEXT VIA
S2	...	wide / medium / close; static or moving	named Part II elements	match cut / whip / scale-reveal

For each cell: name the focal point (where the eye lands first, second, third); name the **Part II elements** by their library names ("UI Card v2 + Counting Number + Connection Line"); and specify the transition *logic*, not just its type, "the card's corner becomes the next scene's frame (match cut)," not "fade."

4.4 Asset list

Three buckets, filled before you open AE so you never stop mid-build to find a font.

BUCKET	WHAT GOES HERE	EXAMPLES (STRIPE)
BUILD	Everything constructed in AE/Illustrator	UI cards, connection lines, network nodes, counter, chart, logo anim
CAPTURE	Real screen recordings	Dashboard walkthrough, a real API call in a terminal
SOURCE	Found / licensed assets	Inter / Söhne-style font, device mockup, music bed, brand SVG logo

4.5 The animatic gate

Assemble storyboard frames + scratch VO + temp music into a rough *timed* cut to test pacing before full animation. Record a scratch VO on your phone, drop each frame on the timeline sized to its VO line, lay temp music at the final-ish BPM, and add rough cuts where transitions will go. Then check it , and fix it now, for free:

CHECK	PASS CONDITION	FIX IF IT FAILS
Muted at 1.5×	Story reads with no sound, sped up	Cut a beat; strengthen the hero frame
Dead beats	No shot sits >2.5s without new info	Trim or split into two ideas
Hook timing	Tension clear by 0:03	Re-cut the open; lead with the strongest frame
VO/visual sync	Each line lands on its frame	Slide frames; rewrite the line to fit the second
Total runtime	Within 45-90s	Cut the optional proof beat first
Rhythm vs music	Cuts roughly land on downbeats	Nudge cuts to the temp track's beats

TAKEAWAY

The animatic is where you fail cheaply. If it doesn't work muted at 1.5×, no amount of polish will save it, fix the cut, not the keyframes.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Three tone words locked
- ✓ Style frames approved at 50% zoom
- ✓ Storyboard table complete, elements named
- ✓ Asset list bucketed and prepped
- ✓ Animatic passes muted-1.5×
- ✓ Dead beats removed before animating



PART I • FOUNDATIONS

5 Voiceover & Narration

VO timing is animation timing. Mark the stressed syllables first, then animate to them, and the whole video feels scored rather than assembled.

SECTIONS

- 5.1 Pace by brand temperature
- 5.2 Writing for the ear
- 5.3 Pause placement
- 5.4 Syncing VO to action

5.1 Pace by brand temperature

FEEL	WORDS/SEC	PRODUCTS
Energetic / consumer	2.6-2.9	Spotify, Duolingo, Canva, Robinhood
Confident / standard SaaS	2.4-2.6	Stripe, Notion, Slack, Linear, Figma, Airtable, Webflow, Miro, HubSpot, Grammarly, Calendly, Loom
Calm / premium	1.9-2.2	Claude, Headspace

5.2 Writing for the ear

- Read every line out loud. If you stumble, the listener will too, rewrite.
- Front-load the meaning: “Ship in days” beats “What this means is you’ll be able to ship in days.”
- Numbers as words for small ones (“three months”); digits in on-screen supers.
- Kill filler: *just, really, simply, basically, in order to.*

5.3 Pause placement

The rhythm that makes VO feel directed, not read:

- **Beat pause (~0.3s)** after the hook, before the problem, lets the tension land.
- **Hard pause (~0.6s)** at the solution reveal, the silence sells the turn. This is where the product logo/UI appears.
- **Micro-pause (~0.15s)** between walkthrough actions, synced to each UI cut.
- Never pause mid-clause; pause at the period, not the comma.

5.4 Syncing VO to action

► BUILD IT, MARK, THEN ANIMATE

1. Animate the **action to land on the stressed syllable**, not the start of the word. “Watch it **set**-tle” → the success-state pulse fires on “set.”
2. In AE: import the final VO, then mark layer markers at each stressed beat (numpad * during a RAM preview drops a marker). Snap your action keyframes to those markers.
3. Leave **0.3-0.5s of breathing room before the CTA** so the last benefit lands before the ask.

★ PRO MOVE

For portfolio pieces a clean AI voice (e.g. ElevenLabs) is acceptable and fast; for client work, hire a VO artist and direct them with your three tone words. Either way, de-ess and high-pass at 80 Hz, and normalize to **-16 LUFS** (web standard, Chapter 6).

TAKEAWAY

VO timing is animation timing, mark the stressed syllables first, then animate to them, and the whole video feels scored rather than assembled.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Pace matches brand temperature
- ✓ Lines read clean out loud
- ✓ Pauses placed at reveals
- ✓ VO marked in AE at stressed syllables
- ✓ Normalized to -16 LUFS
- ✓ Breathing room before the CTA



PART I · FOUNDATIONS

6 Audio Design & Beat-Syncing

Sound-off is the default viewing mode; sound-on is where the work feels expensive. Cut to the music and let SFX punctuate, not perform.

SECTIONS

- 6.1 Music by mood & BPM
- 6.2 The SFX layer beginners skip
- 6.3 Beat-syncing in AE
- 6.4 The final mix

6.1 Music by mood & BPM

CLUSTER	GENRE / MOOD	BPM	PRODUCTS
Confident tech	Minimal electronic; pulsing synth + soft kick	100-120	Stripe, Linear, Webflow, HubSpot
Friendly productivity	Warm indie-electronic, plucky, optimistic	110-125	Notion, Slack, Airtable, Figma, Calendly, Loom, Miro, Grammarly
Upbeat consumer	Pop / electro-pop, bright, hooky	120-130	Spotify, Canva, Robinhood
Playful	Bouncy marimba / synth, comedic stings	115-130	Duolingo
Calm / ambient	Ambient pads, piano, no percussion	60-80 / beatless	Headspace, Claude

Map the BPM in AE: a 120 BPM track has a beat every 0.5 s = every 15 frames at 30 fps. Place a guide layer of markers every 15 frames; cut and accent on them.

6.2 The SFX layer beginners skip

- **UI sounds:** a soft click on each cursor click, a subtle tick on each card fly-in, a high-passed whoosh on slides. Quiet, they punctuate, they don't perform.
- **Transitions:** one sound per cut *type*, used consistently (whip = a short riser; match cut = a soft impact).
- **Reveals:** the solution reveal and the logo lockup each get one designed moment-sound, a riser + impact. This is the audio equivalent of the hard pause.
- **Data/counters:** a rising pitch tied to a counting number; a single ding on a success state.

⚠ PITFALL

If you can hear the SFX as *separate from* the music, it's too loud. SFX sit ~-18 to -12 dB under the music bed. The amateur tell is foley you notice; the goal is foley you only miss when it's gone.

6.3 Beat-syncing in AE

● ANIMATE IT

1. Drop the music in, RAM preview, and tap numpad * on each downbeat to litter the layer with markers, or use **Convert Audio to Keyframes** for an Audio Amplitude null.
2. To pulse an element on the beat, pickwhip its Scale to the amplitude slider (see the expression opposite). Great for a Spotify logo breathing with the kick.
3. **Snap cuts to markers**, not the other way around, let the music dictate the edit rhythm.

EXPRESSION · BEAT-DRIVEN SCALE (PICKWHIP TO AUDIO AMPLITUDE)

```
s = thisComp.layer("Audio Amplitude").effect("Both Channels")("Slider");  
[100 + s*0.4, 100 + s*0.4] // logo/waveform breathes with the kick
```

6.4 The final mix

Music bed -16 to -14 LUFS; VO sits ~6 dB above music (duck the music -4 to -6 dB under VO via auto-ducking or a manual volume keyframe); SFX -18 to -12 dB under music. Master to **-16 LUFS integrated, -1 dB true peak** for web.

TAKEAWAY

Cut to the music and let SFX punctuate, not perform, the difference between “has sound” and “feels scored” is restraint and beat-locked timing.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Track matches the BPM cluster
- ✓ Beat markers placed in AE
- ✓ Cuts land on downbeats
- ✓ One designed moment-sound on the reveal + logo
- ✓ SFX sit under music
- ✓ Mastered to -16 LUFS / -1 dBTP



PART I · FOUNDATIONS

7 Art Direction & the Brand Kit as AE Assets

The fastest way to make work look official is to use the brand's real system, not an approximation, then wire that system into the project so every scene inherits it for free.

SECTIONS

- 7.1 Use the real system
- 7.2 The Brand Controls null
- 7.3 Type, grid, and saved eases
- 7.4 Background systems & legal

7.1 Use the real system

Below are the core kits for all eighteen brands. **Brands refresh, verify each against the live product and the brand's press/guidelines page before final delivery;** treat these as accurate starting points, not gospel.

PRODUCT	PRIMARY COLOR	TYPEFACE (OR SUBSTITUTE)	MOTION IDENTITY
Claude	 #DA7756	Styrene/Tiempos → Inter + a serif	Slow, deliberate; text streams in; minimal
Stripe	 #635BFF	Söhne → Inter	Precise, weightless; connection lines; smooth ease
Notion	 #000000	Inter / system → Inter	Calm, blocky; drag-and-drop; modular
Figma	 #A259FF	Whyte → Inter	Snappy, collaborative; cursors; vector morphs
Slack	 #4A154B	Lato	Friendly bounce; notifications; emoji pops
Linear	 #5E6AD2	Inter	Fast, crisp; snap cuts; subtle glows
Spotify	 #1DB954	Spotify Circular → Montserrat / Poppins	Beat-reactive; bold; energetic
Canva	 #00C4CC	Canva Sans → Poppins	Bouncy; drag/drop; playful pops
Loom	 #625DF5	Inter	Quick, casual; record pulse; bubble cam
Airtable	 #2D7FF9	Inter	Data morphs; grid→view; colorful records
Duolingo	 #58CC02	Feather Bold / din-round → Nunito (rounded)	Squash-and-stretch; bouncy; character-led
Grammarly	 #15C39A	Gerstner / system → Inter	Inline reveals; underline draws; tooltips
Calendly	 #006BFF	Inter / Circular → Inter	Clean; calendar fills; booking flow
Webflow	 #4353FF	Inter	Responsive resize; breakpoint morphs
Miro	 #FFD02F	Inter	Infinite zoom; parallax; sticky physics
Robinhood	 #00C805	Capsule Sans → Inter / Capsule	Chart draw-on; counters; sleek dark

PRODUCT	PRIMARY COLOR	TYPEFACE (OR SUBSTITUTE)	MOTION IDENTITY
Headspace	 #FF7E1D	Apercu / HS Sans → Poppins / Apercu	Slow drift; organic blobs; soft glow
HubSpot	 #FF7A59	Lexend Deca → Lexend	Pipeline flows; funnel viz; connected

7.2 The Brand Controls null

This is what keeps every scene on-brand without re-picking colors. Build it once per product and every linked element inherits the kit.

► BUILD IT, THE BRAND CONTROLS NULL

1. Create a null; add `Effect > Expression Controls > Color Control`, one per brand color, renamed ("Primary," "Accent1"...).
2. Any layer's fill references it: `thisComp.layer("Brand Controls").effect("Primary")("Color")`.
3. Change the master once → every linked element updates. This is your brand single-source-of-truth.

7.3 Type, grid, and saved eases

- **Type styles.** Install the real font (or substitute). Make one text layer per style, H1, H2, Body, Caption, at the right size/tracking/leading, and save each as an Animation Preset. Typical 1080p scale: H1 96 px / H2 56 px / Body 32 px / Caption 24 px, tracking -20 on headlines, leading 1.2x.
- **Grid & safe areas.** Title/Action Safe on; a 12-column grid at 1920 wide with ~80 px margins, 24 px gutters. Snap UI to it.
- **Motion identity = saved eases.** Build the brand's signature ease once in the Graph Editor (or Flow), save it named per brand ("Stripe_smooth," "Duolingo_bounce"), and apply the *same* ease to every move. Inconsistent easing reads as amateur instantly.
- **Background system.** Pre-comp the brand background once (Stripe's angled gradient, Headspace's drifting blobs, Linear's near-black vignette), name it `BG/<product>`, and drop it under every scene.

7.4 Legal & the regulated note

◆ BRAND NOTE

For **portfolio (spec) work**, brand use is generally fine as clearly-unofficial homage; never imply official endorsement. For **regulated products (Robinhood)** include the real-world disclaimer super, "Investing involves risk, including loss of principal." For paid client work, use only assets the client provides or licenses. Label spec pieces "concept."

TAKEAWAY

Build a Brand Controls null + saved type presets + one signature ease per product, and every future scene inherits the brand for free, that inheritance is what makes spec work look officially sanctioned.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Real hex codes verified against the live brand
- ✓ Brand Controls null built
- ✓ Type styles saved as presets
- ✓ Grid / safe guides on
- ✓ Signature ease saved
- ✓ Background comp built
- ✓ Disclaimer supers where required



PART I • FOUNDATIONS

8 Motion Design Principles

These aren't theory, they are the pass/fail rules the QA rubric enforces. Most of the craft is scale, opacity, and position with consistent easing; flash is the exception, clarity is the job.

SECTIONS

- 8.1 Story & message
- 8.2 Timing & pacing
- 8.3 Clarity & hierarchy
- 8.4 Meaning, restraint & craft

8.1 Story & message

- **One message per scene.** If a shot makes two points, split it.
- **Animate ideas, not UI details.** Show what the product does for the user, not every pixel of chrome.
- **Show the problem before the solution.** Tension first, relief second, always.
- **Reveal progressively.** Bring in what the VO is talking about, when it talks about it.
- **Cut as soon as the point lands.** Dead frames kill energy.

8.2 Timing & pacing

- **2-5s shots.** Longer drags, shorter confuses. Most live at 2.5-3.5s.
- **Match speed to narration.** Fast VO → snappier moves; calm VO → slow drifts.
- **Don't animate everything at once.** Stagger. The eye reads sequence, not simultaneity.
- **Scale / opacity / position before complex effects.** 90% of great motion is those three with good easing.
- **Consistent easing.** One signature ease per brand. Mixed eases read as amateur.

8.3 Clarity & hierarchy (designed for sound-off)

- **Clarity over flash.** If a flashy move costs comprehension, cut it.
- **Direct attention with motion & contrast.** The thing that moves, or the only thing still in a moving frame, is where the eye goes.
- **One focal point per frame.** Size, contrast, and motion rank everything else.
- **Text readable in 1-2s.** Minimal on-screen text; large UI; consistent spacing.
- **Design for sound-off.** The story must read with captions and visuals alone.

8.4 Meaning, restraint & craft

- **Motion shows cause→effect.** A click *causes* the panel; data *flows* from A to B. Spatial logic is meaning.
- **Purposeful transitions.** Each carries momentum or meaning; never decorative.
- **Subtle secondary motion.** Ambient float/parallax adds life, barely perceptible.
- **Sparing depth.** A little 3D/DOF goes far; too much looks like a screensaver.
- **Simple over crowded.** When in doubt, remove an element.
- **Reusable systems, labeled pre-comps, preview at playback speed, check at 50% zoom.**

⊖ LITMUS

Run on every scene: *can someone understand this muted, at 1.5x?* If not, simplify the frame, slow the idea, or strengthen the focal point. Applied ruthlessly, this one rule is the entire difference between tutorial output and agency output.

TAKEAWAY

Most of the craft is scale/opacity/position with consistent easing, one idea per frame, problem-before-solution, and ruthless cutting, flash is the exception, clarity is the job.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ One message per scene
- ✓ Shots 2-5s; nothing static >2.5s without new info
- ✓ Staggered, not simultaneous
- ✓ One signature ease
- ✓ Readable at 50% / muted-1.5×
- ✓ Motion encodes cause→effect
- ✓ Pre-comps labeled



PART I • FOUNDATIONS

9 Project Setup, Hygiene & Reusable Systems

Decide your tool boundaries and easing identity before the first keyframe.

Consistency is what separates agency work from tutorial work, and most of it is set once and reused forever.

SECTIONS

- 9.1 Tooling & division of labour
- 9.2 Plugins (with free fallbacks)
- 9.3 Project hygiene defaults
- 9.4 Parametrized reuse

9.1 Tooling & division of labour

TOOL	USED FOR	WHY NOT AE
Illustrator	Vector source: icons, logos, isometric scenes	Faster for clean vector art; import layered <code>.ai</code> → Create Shapes from Vector Layer
Figma	Style frames, UI mockups, design tokens	Design the <i>look</i> at final fidelity, then rebuild/import to AE
After Effects	All motion, comp assembly, the element library	The build-and-animate engine, everything lands here
Premiere	Animatic assembly, final edit, VO cleanup, captions	Faster scrubbing and audio editing for cut-based work

9.2 Plugins (with free fallbacks)

Nothing in this book is gated behind a paid plugin; every one has a built-in fallback.

PLUGIN	JOB	FREE FALLBACK
Flow	Visual easing-curve editor, saved presets	Native Graph Editor + Easy Ease (F9)
Motion 4 / Tools Pro	Anchor snapping, fast rigging, ease shortcuts	Pan-Behind (Y), manual expressions
Overlord	One-click Illustrator → AE vector transfer	<code>.ai</code> import + Create Shapes
GEOlayers / Newton	Maps / 2D physics	Keyframe by hand
Trapcode Particular	Particles, light streaks	CC Particle World (built-in)
Saber (free)	Glow, light streaks, energy lines	Built-in Glow + Fast Box Blur

9.3 Project hygiene defaults

- Master comp **1920×1080, 30 fps** (29.97 only if broadcast). Square 1080×1080; vertical 1080×1920.
- Working color sRGB, **16-bit** project depth for gradient-heavy work (Stripe, Headspace) to avoid banding.
- Folder structure: `00_COMPS` / `01_PRECOMPS` / `02_ASSETS` (footage, vector, audio) / `03_BRAND` (solids, control nulls). Colour-label each.
- **Global easing identity**: one signature ease per brand, never deviated. House default for SaaS: velocity **Influence 80% out / 20% in**, snappy departure, soft arrival.

9.4 Parametrized reuse

★ PRO MOVE

Parametrize every element with a Brand Controls null and slider controls so one master comp drives many instances. Duplicate the pre-comp, retime, recolor via the null, never rebuild. This single habit is what turns Part III from eighteen builds into one build reused eighteen times.

TAKEAWAY

Decide tool boundaries and easing identity before the first keyframe; set the hygiene defaults once, duplicate the folder template, and let parametrized pre-comps carry the consistency the rest of the book depends on.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Comp presets saved
- ✓ 16-bit on for gradients
- ✓ Folder template duplicated
- ✓ Plugins or fallbacks confirmed
- ✓ House ease decided
- ✓ Brand Controls + slider parametrization in place



PART II

The Technique Codex

The reusable element library, the heart of the book. Build each element once, pre-comp it, name it well, and redeploy it across all eighteen videos. Every entry: build, animate, when, which brands, a pitfall, a pro move, and a variation.



IN THIS PART

- 10 UI & Product Capture
- 11 Typography in Motion
- 12 Graphics & Illustration
- 13 Data Visualization
- 14 Transitions & Camera
- 15 Emphasis & Micro-Interactions
- 16 Branding & Atmosphere



PART II • THE TECHNIQUE CODEX

10 UI & Product Capture

The UI card is the atom of every SaaS explainer. Real UI feeling comes from soft layered shadows, arced cursor moves with squashy clicks, captured footage cropped-and-pushed, and index-based typing, never flat fades.

SECTIONS

- 10.1 The UI card
- 10.2 Cursor, click, hover, drag
- 10.3 Screen-recording treatment
- 10.4 Form-fill & typing

10.1 The UI card

When: any time you show interface, dashboard tiles, message bubbles, settings panels. **Brands:** all eighteen.

► BUILD IT

1. **Rounded rect:** Rectangle tool → shape layer; Size (e.g. 480×300), Roundness **16** (Notion ~6, Duolingo ~24).
2. **Fill:** white or brand surface; turn the **Stroke** on at 1 px #E5E7EB, the subtle border is what makes it read as a real card, not a flat block.
3. **Drop shadow:** Effect > Perspective > Drop Shadow, Opacity 18%, Distance 8, Softness 24. Add a second softer shadow (Distance 24, Softness 60, Opacity 8%). Real UI uses *layered* soft shadows, never one hard one.
4. **Inner content:** text layers (saved Body/Caption presets), an icon (§12), small sub-shapes. Keep consistent 24 px padding.
5. **Group & pre-comp** as UI/Card_<type> ; center the anchor so it scales from center.

● ANIMATE IT, THE CARD FLY-IN

1. Position +60 px below → rest; Scale 92→100; Opacity 0→100. All over **12 frames**, ease 80/20.
2. Add **one frame of overshoot** on scale (92→102→100) for life, but only for playful brands (Duolingo, Slack, Canva). Stripe/Linear get a clean stop.
3. Stagger multiple cards by **2-3 frames** each. Never fly them in on the same frame.

⚠ PITFALL

Animating Position *and* a heavy baked-in drop shadow makes the shadow lag weirdly. Keep the shadow on the card layer so it moves with it, and never scale a card with a fixed-pixel stroke past ~110% or the stroke visibly thickens.

10.2 Cursor, click, hover, drag-and-drop

When: demonstrating an action. **Brands:** Notion, Airtable, Canva, Figma, Webflow, Miro, Calendly, HubSpot.

► BUILD IT

1. **Cursor:** the macOS arrow as a 5-point shape (white fill + 1 px dark stroke) or an SVG. Pre-comp UI/Cursor ; anchor at the tip.
2. **Click ring:** a stroke-only circle, anchored center, parented to the cursor.
3. **Hover state:** a duplicate of the target with a lighter fill / raised shadow to cross-fade to.

● ANIMATE IT, ARC, SQUASH, MAKE ROOM

- **Move** with ease 70/30 and a gentle *arc* (pull the spatial bezier, real hands arc, never straight). Settle with a 1-2 px overshoot.
- **Click**: cursor scales 100→90→100 over 6 frames; the ring scales 0→160% while opacity 100→0 over 10 frames. Trigger the target's state change *on* the click frame.
- **Drag-and-drop**: on pickup, lift the element (Scale 100→104, shadow 8→20); parent it to the cursor; on drop, scale back and **nudge neighbors aside**, that make-room motion is what sells a real reorder.

⚠️ PITFALL

Linear cursor moves and instant clicks. Hands accelerate, arc, and decelerate; clicks have a tiny squash. Skip those and the demo reads robotic, the single fastest way to look amateur on a UI-heavy brand.

10.3 Screen-recording treatment

When: real product demos. **Brands**: Stripe, Linear, HubSpot, Airtable, Loom, Webflow.

▶ BUILD IT

1. Capture at **2× the final resolution** (a 2560-wide window for a 1080 comp) so you can push in without softness.
2. Clean it: hide personal data, use demo content, full-screen the app, hide bookmarks/notifications.
3. Frame it inside a browser/device mockup (§16), raw recordings look like screen-share; framed ones look like product film.

● ANIMATE IT, CROP, PUSH, EMPHASIZE

- **Don't just play it.** Cut into 2-4s beats, each one action. Add a slow camera push (Scale 100→106, ease-in only) toward the active region.
- Sync UI events: drop a built click-ring on top of each captured click, perfectly aligned.
- Use **time-remapping** to trim dead air, keyframe past loading spinners. The demo should feel faster than real life.

10.4 Form-fill & typing UI

When: sign-up, search, prompt entry. **Brands**: Claude, Grammarly, Stripe (code), Robinhood (search), Spotify (search).

● ANIMATE IT, THE TYPING REVEAL

1. Use the **Type-On** approach: text layer → add a Range Selector, animate **End** 0→100% over the line, Units = Index. Set Advanced > Shape = Square, Smoothness 0 for a hard per-character pop.
2. Caret blink via expression (opposite); parent the caret X to the typing point. Speed ~**18-25 chars/sec** to read as human typing.

EXPRESSION • CARET BLINK (~2 BLINKS/SEC, ON THE CARET'S OPACITY)

```
Math.round(time*2) % 2 * 100 // 0 or 100, steps twice a second
```

⚠ PITFALL

Revealing text by an Opacity fade of the whole block is not “typing,” it’s a fade. Use the Range Selector index reveal so characters appear one by one.

TAKEAWAY

Real UI feeling comes from soft layered shadows, arced cursor moves with squashy clicks, captured footage cropped-and-pushed, and index-based typing, never flat fades.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Card uses layered soft shadows + 1 px border; anchor centered
- ✓ Cursor arcs and clicks squash
- ✓ Recordings captured 2× and framed in a mockup
- ✓ Typing uses a Range Selector index reveal
- ✓ Drag-and-drop nudges neighbors to make room



PART II · THE TECHNIQUE CODEX

11 Typography in Motion

One reveal style per video, repeated, consistency is polish. Headlines must be readable at 50% zoom and on screen long enough to land in under a second.

SECTIONS

- 11.1 Build for motion
- 11.2 The three house reveals
- 11.3 Stressed-word emphasis
- 11.4 Readability rules

11.1 Build for motion

When: hooks, benefit lines, CTAs, especially Claude, Linear, Stripe, and Spotify hooks. Use your saved H1 preset. For multi-word emphasis, split into separate layers per word (or per-word Range Selectors) so words move independently. For a masked reveal, parent the text to a rectangle mask and reveal by moving the text up behind the mask edge.

11.2 The three house reveals

● ANIMATE IT, PICK ONE, REPEAT IT

1. **Rise-and-fade (default):** Position +40 px→0, Opacity 0→100, 12 frames, ease 80/20. Per-word stagger 2 frames via a Range Selector Offset.
2. **Mask wipe:** add Linear Wipe, animate Transition Completion 100→0 over 15 frames; Feather 0 hard, 20 soft. Wipe direction matches reading direction.
3. **Tracking expand:** animate Tracking -8→0 while Opacity 0→100, letters draw together as they appear. Premium; great for Stripe and Claude.

⚠ PITFALL

Animating every word with a different effect. Pick *one* reveal per video and repeat it, consistency equals polish. The second tell: text unreadable in under a second (too small, on too briefly, low contrast).

11.3 Stressed-word emphasis

Scale one key word 100→108 on its stressed syllable (synced to the VO marker, §5), then settle to 100. This makes the headline feel spoken rather than placed, the typographic echo of the vocal stress.

◆ BRAND NOTE

Claude / Stripe: tracking-expand, no bounce, considered. **Spotify / Canva:** rise-and-fade with a touch of overshoot, energetic. **Linear:** mask-wipe, fast and hard-edged. Match the reveal to the brand temperature, then never change it within a video.

11.4 Readability rules

⊖ LITMUS

Headlines must survive at 50% zoom on a phone, muted. If you can't read it at a glance in the first second it's on screen, make it bigger, hold it longer, or raise the contrast, before you touch the animation.

TAKEAWAY

One reveal style per video, repeated; per-word stagger for life; a single stressed-word scale synced to the VO, and every headline readable at 50% zoom, muted.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ One text-reveal style for the whole video
- ✓ Per-word stagger ~2 frames
- ✓ Stressed word scaled on its VO marker
- ✓ Headline readable at 50% zoom in <1s
- ✓ Wipe/stagger direction matches reading direction



PART II · THE TECHNIQUE CODEX

12 Graphics & Illustration

Icons sequenced with consistent stroke weights; characters that live through overlapping action and squash; glass that uses real blur-behind; and gradients that live in 16-bit with noise dither.

SECTIONS

- 12.1 Icon animation
- 12.2 Character & isometric rigs
- 12.3 Glassmorphism
- 12.4 Living gradients (16-bit)

12.1 Icon animation

When: feature callouts, benefit beats. **Brands:** all.

► BUILD IT

Import icons as SVG/ `.ai` → Create Shapes from Vector Layer so paths stay editable. Set anchor to center. Keep stroke width consistent across the set (e.g. 2 px), mismatched weights look amateur instantly.

● ANIMATE IT

Scale 0→100 with a slight overshoot (+1 frame to 105); or **draw-on** the stroke with `Add > Trim Paths`, End 0→100. Rotate-in for refreshes. Stagger icon + label by 3 frames. **Never** pop all icons simultaneously, sequence them.

12.2 Character & isometric rigs

When: problem-state metaphors, brand worlds. **Brands:** Duolingo (character), Headspace (organic), Canva, Slack.

► BUILD IT

Design in Illustrator on a 2:1 isometric grid; import layered; separate every moving part onto its own layer; set each anchor at the natural pivot (an arm pivots at the shoulder).

● ANIMATE IT, OVERLAPPING ACTION + SQUASH

Parent body parts hierarchically (hand → forearm → upper arm → torso). Use **squash-and-stretch** on Scale (a bounce: 100/100 → 110/90 → 95/105 → 100/100) and **overlapping action** (delay child parts 2-3 frames behind the parent). Add a secondary idle loop. Life is in the lag, not the pose.

EXPRESSION · IDLE BREATHING LOOP (ON A TORSO'S SCALE Y)

```
loopOut("pingpong") // with two keyframes 100 -> 101 over ~1s; barely perceptible
```

12.3 Glassmorphism

When: premium reveals, backgrounds. **Brands:** Stripe, Headspace, Robinhood, Apple-grade hero frames.

► BUILD IT

Place the card over content; duplicate the *background* below; mask it to the card shape; apply **Fast Box Blur** (radius ~30, Repeat Edge Pixels on) to that masked copy for a real frosted blur-behind. Add a 1 px white stroke at 40% and a subtle top inner highlight. Fill the card white at ~12% opacity.

12.4 Living gradients (16-bit)

► BUILD IT

Use a **4-Color Gradient** or Ramp on a solid. For Stripe's signature, build an angled multi-stop gradient in a pre-comp and slowly drift its phase (wiggle the point positions for a living gradient). Work in **16-bit** to kill banding; add 1-2% Noise at low opacity to dither.

⚠️ PITFALL

8-bit gradients band visibly on dark backgrounds (Stripe, Robinhood, Linear). Always 16-bit + dither-noise. This is one of the four faults that, fixed, jump the work a whole tier (\$40).

TAKEAWAY

Sequence icons with consistent stroke weights; let characters live through overlapping action and squash; build glass with a real blur-behind; and keep gradients in 16-bit with a whisper of noise.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Icons sequenced, consistent stroke weight
- ✓ Character anchors at pivots; overlapping action + squash
- ✓ Idle secondary loop on living characters
- ✓ Glass uses real masked blur-behind
- ✓ Gradients 16-bit + noise dither



PART II • THE TECHNIQUE CODEX

13 Data Visualization

Numbers ease-out and decelerate; bars grow from anchored bases; lines draw on with Trim Paths; and data flows via traveling pulses that encode cause→effect. The traveling pulse is the most reusable, most sellable shot in the book.

SECTIONS

- 13.1 Counting numbers
- 13.2 Bars & lines
- 13.3 Progress rings
- 13.4 Connection lines & the traveling pulse

13.1 Counting numbers

When: stats, revenue, prices, scores. **Brands:** Stripe, Robinhood, HubSpot, Duolingo (XP), Spotify (streams). Apply a Slider Control named "Count," keyframe it 0→target over ~1 s ease-out, and format the Source Text:

EXPRESSION • COUNTING NUMBER (REVENUE, WITH COMMAS)

```
// On the text layer's Source Text. Slider "Count" keyframed 0 -> target, ease-out.
n = effect("Count")("Slider");
"$" + n.toFixed(0).replace(/\B(?=(\d{3})+(?!\d))/g, ",");
```

⚠️ PITFALL

A linear count feels mechanical, use ease-out so it decelerates into the final number. And don't count too long; past ~1.2 s it drags. Pair with a rising-pitch SFX.

13.2 Bars & lines

► BUILD IT

Bar: a rectangle per bar, **anchored at the bottom** so it grows upward. **Line:** a pen path through your data points; add a stroke; add an area fill (duplicate the path, close it to the baseline, low-opacity gradient).

● ANIMATE IT, GROW FROM THE BASE, DRAW THE LINE

Bars: Scale Y 0→100 (anchor bottom!), stagger 3 frames each, ease-out. **Line:** Trim Paths End 0→100 over ~1.5 s ease 60/40; parent a glowing dot to the path end so a point rides the drawing line; area fill fades up behind it.

⚠️ PITFALL

Growing bars from center or top (set the anchor to the base), or drawing a line with no easing (real data-draws breathe).

13.3 Progress rings

A circle with stroke only, no fill; Trim Paths End = your percent; pair a counting number in the center. The same draw-on engine as a connection line, wrapped on a circle, reuse the pre-comp.

13.4 Connection lines, network viz & the traveling pulse

The single most valuable move in the whole codex: the one that turns an abstract idea, a request, an automation, an integration, into a thing the eye can watch happen.

When: processes, automations, integrations, the Stripe money-flow. **Brands:** Stripe, Slack (automation), Airtable, HubSpot (pipeline), Calendly, Webflow.

► BUILD IT

1. **Nodes:** small circles (~32×32 px), one per endpoint; fill `BRAND/Surface`, 2 px `Primary` stroke; center each anchor.
2. **The path:** a 2-point pen path between node centers, one shape layer per connection.
3. **Stroke it:** 2-3 px, **round caps** (round caps make a drawn-on line feel intentional, not clipped).
4. **Add Trim Paths**, the draw-on engine; Start 0, End 0 for now.
5. **The packet:** duplicate the stroked path, brighten to `Accent1`, thicken to ~6 px, add a second Trim Paths. This copy is the moving pulse.
6. **Glow the packet** (`Stylize > Glow` ~50/30/1.5, or `Saber`). Pre-comp the rig as `DATA/Connection_Pulse`.

● ANIMATE IT, DRAW, THEN SEND THE PACKET

1. **Draw the line on:** base stroke Trim End 0→100 over 15 frames, ease 60/40.
2. **Send the packet:** on the copy, keyframe *both* Start (52→100%) and End (60→100%) together from the frame the line finishes. The fixed ~8% gap is a short segment that races down the path. Ease 80/20.
3. **Land it:** pulse the target node (Scale 100→115→100) and fire a one-time success ring (§15). Sync the landing to the stressed syllable, "clear the network, and **set**-tle."

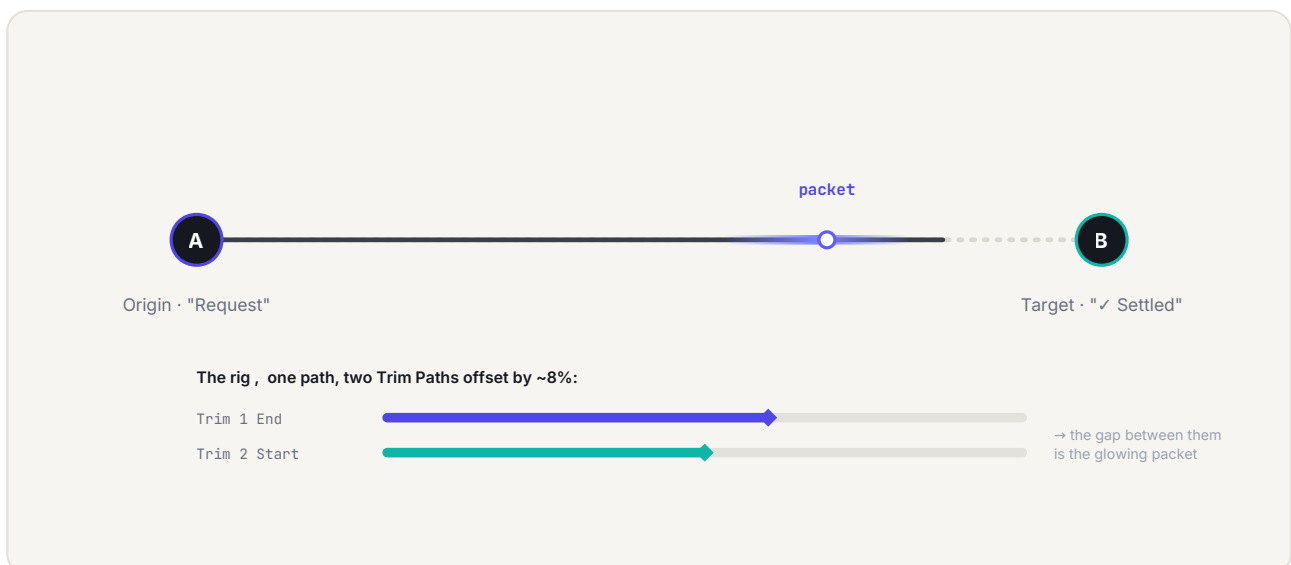


Figure 13.4a, The traveling-pulse rig. A single pen-path carries two Trim Paths. Keyframing both Start (52→100%) and End (60→100%) together renders a short, fixed-length segment that races from node A to node B. Add a Glow and you have the signature data move, no path-sampling expression required.

The two-Trim-Paths method needs *no* path-sampling expression, the segment length is constant and the motion is keyframed, so it retimes cleanly when you slide the scene on the master timeline. Keep the node-arrival bump on an expression, though, so it always fires exactly when the packet lands:

EXPRESSION · NODE ARRIVAL PULSE (NO KEYFRAMES)

```
// On the target node's Scale. Drop a layer marker named "hit" where the packet lands.
// Fires a smooth 100 -> 115 -> 100 bump over 0.4s, then rests. Sin gives an organic ease.
try { t = thisLayer.marker.key("hit").time } catch(e) { t = -999 }
d = time - t;
amp = (d >= 0 && d < 0.4) ? Math.sin(d / 0.4 * Math.PI) * 15 : 0;
[100 + amp, 100 + amp];
```

⚠️ PITFALL

Static lines that just fade in. That throws away the whole point: the *direction and timing* of the pulse *are* the meaning, request, then process, then settle. A pulse with no glow and hard caps reads as a dash, not energy. Round caps + Glow, always.

★ PRO MOVE

For a real **network**, don't keyframe each line by hand. Keyframe one master line and drive every duplicate's Trim End from it with an index-based auto-stagger, so pulses fire node-to-node 4 frames apart and data visibly cascades. Change the master timing once; the whole network re-choreographs.

PRO-MOVE EXPRESSION · AUTO-STAGGER A NETWORK

```
// On each connection line's Trim Paths > End (all lines share one keyframed master).
// Each duplicate fires 4 frames after the one below it -- data visibly flows through the graph.
off = (index - 1) * 4 * thisComp.frameDuration;
valueAtTime(time - off);
```

Variations to keep in the bin

VARIATION	HOW IT DIFFERS	USED BY
Progress ring	Same draw-on, wrapped on a stroked circle; End = the percentage. Center a counting number.	Robinhood, HubSpot, Duolingo
API / money flow	The flagship: packet launches from a highlighted POST line, travels the network, lands on "✓ Settled."	Stripe (§18)
Pipeline flow	Horizontal lanes; a record-card rides the line, changing state-color at each node.	HubSpot, Airtable
Automation spark	Trigger flashes; one fast pulse fans out to multiple targets.	Slack, Calendly routing

◆ BRAND NOTE

Stripe, weightless and precise: one clean packet, no overshoot, glow in #635BFF fading toward cyan; the camera *follows* it (§14). **HubSpot**, warmer and busier: multiple lanes at once, orange-to-teal. **Slack**, playful: arrives with a soft pop and a count badge. **Headspace** would *never* use this, its vocabulary is drift, not transit. Match the move to the brand's temperature, not just its color.

⊖ LITMUS

Mute it, run it at 1.5×: can a stranger tell that *something travelled from here to there and arrived successfully*? If the eye can't follow the packet or can't tell it landed, the move has failed, slow the launch, widen the glow, or make the arrival bigger.

TAKEAWAY

Numbers ease-out; bars grow from anchored bases; lines draw on with Trim Paths; and data flows via a traveling pulse whose direction and timing are the meaning. Get the transit reading muted and you've built the most sellable shot in the book.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Counter eases out with comma formatting
- ✓ Bars anchored at the base
- ✓ Lines use Trim Paths + a riding dot
- ✓ Packet = two offset Trim Paths, ~8% gap, Glow on
- ✓ Pulse direction matches the VO's cause→effect
- ✓ Networks auto-staggered from one master



PART II • THE TECHNIQUE CODEX

14 Transitions & Camera

Overlap every cut, carry momentum across it, reserve match cuts for hero moments, and build depth with a Z-separated, null-driven camera for real parallax.

SECTIONS

- 14.1 The transition bin
- 14.2 Match cut & morph
- 14.3 Whip, scale-reveal, speed ramp
- 14.4 The camera & parallax rig

14.1 The transition bin

When: between every scene, but match the *type* to the brand (snappy for Linear, soft for Headspace). Build each as a reusable pre-comp.

TRANSITION	WHAT IT IS	BEST FOR
Match cut	A shared shape continues across the cut so the eye reads one object. The most premium transition; plan it in the storyboard.	Hero moments (Stripe)
Shape / morph	Two shapes with equal point counts; keyframe Path A→B. Equal points or it tears.	Icon → icon
Mask / swipe	A moving mask (or Linear Wipe) reveals B over A; 12-16 frames, direction carries momentum.	Notion, Canva
Scale reveal	B scales up from a point on A (a button becomes the next screen).	Duolingo, Webflow
Slide / fade / zoom	The workhorses. Always <i>overlap</i> (6-frame), hard cuts-to-black kill flow.	all
Whip cut	Fast directional blur out of A, matching whip into B; hide the cut in the blur. 4-6 frames.	Spotify, Canva

14.2 Match cut & morph

The match cut is the strongest stitch in any film and the centerpiece of the Stripe assembly (§18, §37): the glowing packet launched in the code scene is the *same object* that travels the network in the next scene. Plan it in the storyboard, both scenes must contain the shared object at the same position/scale at the cut. For a morph, keep equal point counts on the two paths or the shape tears between keyframes.

14.3 Whip, scale-reveal, speed ramp

Whip cuts hide the seam inside a motion blur and carry energy, reserve them for the up-tempo brands (Spotify, Canva). A speed ramp (time-remap a move fast→slow) punctuates a reveal. Split-screen / before-after wipes are the classic for Grammarly, Canva, and Calendly. Linear is the one deliberate exception to the overlap rule: a hard snap-cut on the Cmd-K beat *is* the brand signal.

14.4 The camera & parallax rig

► BUILD IT

Enable 3D on your layers and add a **Camera** (35 mm). Push layers apart in Z (background -2000, midground -500, foreground 0). Parent the camera to a **null ("CamRig")** and animate the null, never the camera directly.

● ANIMATE IT, PUSH & PARALLAX

- **Push-in:** move CamRig +Z, ease-in only (start slow, no hard stop). A constant subtle push under a static scene adds life, never let a hero shot be perfectly still.
- **Parallax:** because layers sit at different Z depths, panning the CamRig moves them at different speeds automatically, true parallax, better than faking with offset Position. 2.5D illustrations (Headspace, Duolingo, Miro) come alive this way.

⚠ PITFALL

Animating the camera itself (hard to retime) instead of a parented null; and over-pushing (keep it to 4-8% scale-equivalent over a shot). Enable motion blur on moving layers or fast moves strobe.

TAKEAWAY

Overlap every cut, carry momentum across it, reserve match cuts for hero moments, and build depth with a Z-separated null-driven camera for parallax you can't fake with Position keyframes.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Transition type matches the brand
- ✓ Cuts overlap; never hard-to-black
- ✓ Match cut planned in the storyboard
- ✓ Camera on a parented null
- ✓ Motion blur on for fast moves
- ✓ Subtle constant push on hero shots



PART II • THE TECHNIQUE CODEX

15 Emphasis & Micro-Interactions

One emphasis device per moment; ambient float kept barely perceptible; and micro-interactions, shimmer, check-draw, notification slide, are the cheap details that read as real software.

SECTIONS

- 15.1 Spotlight, glow, pulse
- 15.2 Floating UI & card stacks
- 15.3 Micro-interactions
- 15.4 Success & error states

15.1 Spotlight, glow, pulse

When: directing the eye to one UI element. **Brands:** all UI-heavy ones.

► BUILD IT

Spotlight: duplicate the scene, put a feathered ellipse mask (feather 80) around the focus on top, and darken/blur the full copy beneath. **Callout:** a line (Trim Paths draw-on) + a small label card. **Glow:** Stylize > Glow (or Saber) on the focus. **Pulse ring:** a stroke circle, anchored center.

● ANIMATE IT, ONE DEVICE AT A TIME

Spotlight fades in over 8 frames; the callout line draws on, then the label cards in; the **pulse** = ring Scale 100→180 + Opacity 100→0, looped every ~1.2 s for live/active indicators (notifications, recording dots).

⚠ PITFALL

Spotlighting *and* moving *and* a callout *and* a glow all at once. Pick **one** emphasis per moment, the eye can only follow a single instruction.

15.2 Floating UI & card stacks

When: showcasing an interface as a “world.” **Brands:** Notion, Miro, Figma, Airtable. Put multiple UI cards on separate 3D layers at varied Z; a card stack offsets duplicates by 8 px + slight rotation, decreasing opacity behind.

EXPRESSION • AMBIENT FLOAT (ON A CARD'S POSITION; KEEP IT TINY)

```
wiggle(0.5, 6) // 0.5 wiggles/sec, 6px amplitude on Y; barely perceptible
```

⚠ PITFALL

A float wiggle above ~8 px reads as drift or jitter. Ambient motion must be felt, not seen, if a viewer notices it, halve it.

15.3 Micro-interactions

The small touches that signal “this is real software,” each a tiny reusable pre-comp:

- **Notification:** a small card slides from top-right (Position + 20 px overshoot, ease 80/20), holds 1.5 s, slides out. Soft pop SFX + a count badge that scales 0→100 with bounce.
- **Tooltip:** a small card scales 0→100 from its pointer corner (anchor at the tip), 8 frames; arrow included. Grammarly's suggestion = tooltip + content.
- **Loader:** a stroke arc with Rotation expression `time*360` (1 rev/sec), or Trim Paths start/end chasing.

- **Skeleton loader:** gray rounded rects where content will be, with a **shimmer** (a masked white gradient swiping left→right, looped), then cross-fade to real content. This one touch makes a loading state look genuinely engineered.

15.4 Success & error states

● ANIMATE IT, NEVER SNAP TO A STATE

Success: a green circle scales in (overshoot) + a **checkmark draws on** (Trim Paths End 0→100, 8 frames) + a one-time ring pulse. **Error:** red, an X draws or a short horizontal shake (3 keyframes ±6 px). Snapping straight to the final state looks like a mockup; the draw-on is what sells real software.

TAKEAWAY

One emphasis device per moment; ambient float barely perceptible; and micro-interactions, the shimmer-to-content, the check-draw, the notification slide, are the cheap details that read as engineered, not mocked up.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ One emphasis per moment
- ✓ Pulse loops for live indicators
- ✓ Float wiggle ≤6 px
- ✓ Skeleton → content shimmer
- ✓ Success = scale-in + check-draw + pulse



PART II · THE TECHNIQUE CODEX

16 Branding & Atmosphere

Frame UI in mockups masked precisely; make the logo's animation match the brand's energy; and keep atmosphere felt-but-not-seen behind the message.

SECTIONS

- 16.1 Device & browser mockups
- 16.2 Three logo systems
- 16.3 Particles, streaks, depth
- 16.4 Ambient loops

16.1 Device & browser mockups

When: placing UI in a real-world frame. **Brands:** all (Robinhood/Duolingo = phone; Stripe/Linear/Webflow = browser/laptop).

► BUILD IT

Browser: a rounded rect (radius 12) with a top bar, three traffic-light dots, a URL pill with the brand URL; the screen recording/UI masked to the content area. **Phone:** a rounded rect (radius ~48), thin bezel, notch/island, screen masked inside. For 3D, generate an angled device render (Rotato/Figma) and composite.

⚠️ PITFALL

UI not masked precisely to the screen, corners poke out. Match the mask radius to the device radius exactly.

16.2 Three logo systems

When: the close (and sometimes a brief open), your signature moment. Import the brand SVG, Create Shapes from Vector Layer, separate logomark from wordmark, then match the animation to the brand:

SYSTEM	HOW IT MOVES	BRANDS
Draw-on	Trim Paths on the mark's strokes End 0→100, then the wordmark tracks-in (Tracking -6→0 + Opacity).	Stripe, Linear, Calendly
Build-from-parts	Each piece flies/scales in staggered, snapping with a tiny overshoot.	Slack hash, Figma, Airtable, Duolingo
Reveal-mask	A clean wipe reveals the wordmark; calm, no bounce.	Notion, Claude

Settle on a held final state with a one-time subtle shine sweep (a masked light bar crossing the logo).

⚠️ PITFALL

Over-animating the logo (spins, bounces) for a serious brand. Match energy to brand, Duolingo can bounce; Stripe draws on cleanly and stops.

16.3 Particles, streaks, depth

When: backgrounds, atmosphere, the "expensive" feel. **Brands:** Headspace (ambient), Spotify (particles/streaks), Stripe (light streaks), Robinhood (depth).

- **Particles:** CC Particle World or Particular, slow, sparse, low-opacity motes drifting up; atmosphere, not snow.

- **Light streaks:** thin elongated white shapes with heavy directional blur + Glow, drifting at an angle, low opacity (Stripe energy).
- **Depth of field:** enable on the Camera (Aperture up), or fake with graduated Fast Box Blur on background layers; foreground bokeh = blurred bright circles.

16.4 Ambient loops

► BUILD IT

For Headspace, two large soft-gradient blobs (feathered ellipses, Add blend) slowly drifting and scaling on `loopOut("pingpong")` over 8-12 s, endless calm motion. Pre-comp as `BG/ambient_loop`.

⚠️ PITFALL

Atmosphere louder than content. These sit at low opacity behind everything; if a viewer *notices* the particles, dial them back 50%.

TAKEAWAY

Frame UI in precisely-masked mockups, match the logo's animation style to the brand's energy, and keep atmosphere felt-but-not-seen behind the message.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Mockup mask matches the device radius
- ✓ Logo animation style matches brand energy
- ✓ One shine sweep on the logo hold
- ✓ Particles/streaks low-opacity
- ✓ Ambient BG pre-comped & looped
- ✓ Atmosphere never out-shouts content

Master takeaway, Part II: you now own a labeled library, cards, cursors, captured footage, typing, kinetic type, icons, characters, glass, gradients, counters, charts, the connection pulse, the transition bin, the camera rig, emphasis, micro-interactions, mockups, logos, and atmosphere. Build each once, parametrize with the Brand Controls null, and every one of the eighteen videos becomes assembly, not invention.



PART III

The 18 Brand Studies

Each brand carried end-to-end, strategy → script → storyboard → brand kit → shot-by-shot timeline → build. All eighteen built in full; none left as “apply the template.” Stripe is the flagship.



IN THIS PART

- 17 Claude
- 18 Stripe, flagship
- 19 Notion
- 20 Figma
- 21 Slack
- 22 Linear
- 23 Spotify
- 24 Canva
- 25 Loom



PART III • THE 18 BRAND STUDIES

17 Claude

“It does the hard thinking with you, not for you.”, carried end to end: brief, kit, timed script, technique cluster, shot-by-shot timeline, and the assembly note.

SECTIONS

- 17.1 The brief & the angle
- 17.2 Brand kit & pace
- 17.3 The script
- 17.4 Technique cluster & timeline

17.1 The brief & the angle

THE BRIEF

Buyer	B2C + B2B
Value prop	An AI assistant that thinks carefully and works alongside you.
THE single message	"It does the hard thinking <i>with</i> you, not <i>for</i> you."
Angle shift	B2C: creativity / everyday tasks → B2B: a secure, capable teammate that scales knowledge work.

17.2 Brand kit & pace

BRAND KIT

Palette	 #DA7756 ·  #3D3D3A
Background	Warm off-white #F0EEE6, paper-like
Typeface	Styrene/Tiempos → Inter + a serif
Motion identity	Slow, deliberate; text streams in; minimal
Music / BPM	Calm / premium · 60-80 (or beatless)
VO pace	1.9-2.2 words/sec
Tone words	calm, careful, warm

◆ BRAND NOTE

Restraint is the brand. No hype words, no bounce, no overshoot. The streaming-text reveal should feel like considered thought arriving, not a loading bar. Use the tracking-expand headline reveal and the reveal-mask logo; never let anything pop.

17.3 The script

THE SCRIPT, TIMED, PRODUCTION-READY

[Hook · 0:00-0:04] "You don't need an answer. You need to think it through."

[Problem · 0:04-0:13] "Most AI spits out the first thing it guesses, confident, fast, and sometimes just wrong."

[Solution · 0:13-0:21] "Claude is built to reason. To weigh it, check it, and explain its thinking."

[Walkthrough · 0:21-0:48] "Ask it something hard. Watch it work the problem, step by step. Drop in a document, it reads all of it. Push back, and it reconsiders instead of caving."

[Benefits · 0:48-0:62] "So you get answers you can actually trust, for code, for writing, for the decision you've been stuck on."

[CTA • 0:62-0:68] "Think it through with Claude. Free to try."

17.4 Technique cluster & timeline

What this brand forces: Typing / streaming text (§12), reveal-mask logo (§23), error-state beat (§21), drag-drop document (§11), ambient pad atmosphere (§23).

SHOT-BY-SHOT TIMELINE, CLAUDE

TC	BEAT	ON-SCREEN (ELEMENTS)	AUDIO CUE	TRANSITION OUT
0:00-0:04	Hook	BG/ Claude + kinetic type (hook line)	music in (~60-80 BPM), riser	carry momentum into the problem
0:04-0:13	Problem	the messy status quo; spotlight on the chaos (§15)	low/tense ticks, rumble	match cut into the solution reveal
0:13-0:21	Solution	product UI reveal + logo reveal (reveal-mask)	hard pause (0.6s) → clean impact	camera push into the walkthrough
0:21-0:48	Walkthrough	the hero: streaming, considered reply types on; a document drops in; it reconsiders	per-action SFX; rising pitch on the hero move	object-continuous cut to benefits
0:48-0:62	Benefits	benefit lines as kinetic type + device/browser mockup (§16)	warm music swell	mockup recedes; proof/logo fades up
0:62-0:68	CTA	reveal-mask logo lockup + shine sweep + CTA caption	final impact; music resolves	hold ~1.5s, fade to brand BG

⊖ LITMUS

Mute it, run it at 1.5×: does a stranger grasp *It does the hard thinking with you, not for you.* from the visuals alone? If the hero move, streaming, considered reply types on; a document drops in; it reconsiders, doesn't read silent and sped-up, simplify the frame before you polish the keyframes.

TAKEAWAY

Claude is the same seven-beat skeleton tuned to a calm, careful, warm temperature: its kit, its pace, and one forced technique cluster carry the single message, "It does the hard thinking with you, not for you.", from hook to CTA.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Real hex codes / fonts verified against the live brand
- ✓ One signature ease applied to every move
- ✓ The hero move reads muted at 1.5×
- ✓ Cuts on downbeats; key action on the stressed syllable
- ✓ Logo animation style matches brand energy



PART III · THE 18 BRAND STUDIES

18 Stripe, flagship

“Money movement, solved with a few lines of code.”, carried end to end: brief, kit, timed script, technique cluster, shot-by-shot timeline, and the assembly note.

SECTIONS

- 18.1 The brief & the angle
- 18.2 Brand kit & pace
- 18.3 The script
- 18.4 Technique cluster & timeline

18.1 The brief & the angle

THE BRIEF

Buyer	B2B (devs + finance)
Value prop	Payments infrastructure you integrate in minutes, not months.
THE single message	"Money movement, solved with a few lines of code."
Angle shift	Dev angle: clean API → Finance angle: unified revenue dashboard & reporting.

18.2 Brand kit & pace

BRAND KIT

Palette	 #635BFF ·  #00C4CC
Background	Dark #0A2540 or white; signature angled gradients
Typeface	Söhne → Inter
Motion identity	Precise, weightless; connection lines; smooth ease
Music / BPM	Confident tech · 100-120
VO pace	2.4-2.6 words/sec
Tone words	precise, confident, effortless

◆ BRAND NOTE

The flagship build (Chapter 36 assembles it end to end). The packet that launches off the highlighted POST line in Walk 1 is the *same object* that travels the network in Walk 2, object-continuity across the cut is the strongest stitch in the film. 80s master because it carries the full assembly.

18.3 The script

THE SCRIPT, TIMED, PRODUCTION-READY

[Hook · 0:00-0:04] "Accepting payments used to take a team and three months."

[Problem · 0:04-0:14] "Banks, gateways, compliance, fraud, every piece a separate integration, every integration a delay."

[Solution · 0:14-0:23] "Stripe is one set of APIs for the entire money stack."

[Walkthrough · 0:23-0:52] "A few lines of code, and you're taking payments. Watch the request hit Stripe, clear the network, and settle. Refunds, subscriptions, payouts, same clean API. And every transaction lands in one dashboard."

[Benefits · 0:52-0:66] "So your engineers ship in days, and your finance team finally sees revenue in real time."

[Proof · 0:66-0:72] "Millions of businesses, from startups to the Fortune 500."

[CTA · 0:72-0:80] "Start building. Read the docs at stripe.com."

18.4 Technique cluster & timeline

What this brand forces: The flagship cluster: typing code (§12), the traveling pulse / API-flow (§13.4), counting numbers + line chart (§13), browser mockup (§22), logo draw-on + shine (§23), 16-bit gradient atmosphere (§16).

SHOT-BY-SHOT TIMELINE, STRIPE

TC	BEAT	ON-SCREEN (ELEMENTS)	AUDIO CUE	TRANSITION OUT
0:00-0:04	Hook	BG/ Stripe + kinetic type (hook line)	music in (~100-120 BPM), riser	carry momentum into the problem
0:04-0:14	Problem	the messy status quo; spotlight on the chaos (§15)	low/tense ticks, rumble	match cut into the solution reveal
0:14-0:23	Solution	product UI reveal + logo reveal (draw-on)	hard pause (0.6s) → clean impact	camera push into the walkthrough
0:23-0:52	Walkthrough	the hero: code types on, emits a packet that travels the network and settles in a live dashboard	per-action SFX; rising pitch on the hero move	object-continuous cut to benefits
0:52-0:66	Benefits	benefit lines as kinetic type + device/ browser mockup (§16)	warm music swell	mockup recedes; proof/logo fades up
0:66-0:72	Proof	logo grid staggered + counting number (§13)	subtle swell	grid resolves toward center
0:72-0:80	CTA	draw-on logo lockup + shine	final impact; music resolves	hold ~1.5s, fade to brand BG

TC	BEAT	ON-SCREEN (ELEMENTS)	AUDIO CUE	TRANSITION OUT
		sweep + CTA caption		

★ PRO MOVE

This is the flagship. Chapter 37 assembles it end to end, eight scene comps stitched with momentum-carrying transitions. The defining stitch: the glowing packet launched off the highlighted POST line in the code scene is the *same object* that travels the network in the next scene (object-continuity across the cut). The connection-pulse (§13.4) is the centerpiece; the camera follows the packet, and the success ring fires on the stressed syllable of “set-tle.” 80s master because it carries the full assembly.

⊖ LITMUS

Mute it, run it at 1.5×: does a stranger grasp *Money movement, solved with a few lines of code.* from the visuals alone? If the hero move, code types on, emits a packet that travels the network and settles in a live dashboard, doesn’t read silent and sped-up, simplify the frame before you polish the keyframes.

TAKEAWAY

Stripe is the same seven-beat skeleton tuned to a precise, confident, effortless temperature: its kit, its pace, and one forced technique cluster carry the single message, “Money movement, solved with a few lines of code.”, from hook to CTA.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Real hex codes / fonts verified against the live brand
- ✓ One signature ease applied to every move
- ✓ The hero move reads muted at 1.5×
- ✓ Cuts on downbeats; key action on the stressed syllable
- ✓ Logo animation style matches brand energy



PART III • THE 18 BRAND STUDIES

19 Notion

“Replace five tools with one canvas you shape yourself.”, carried end to end: brief, kit, timed script, technique cluster, shot-by-shot timeline, and the assembly note.

SECTIONS

- 19.1 The brief & the angle
- 19.2 Brand kit & pace
- 19.3 The script
- 19.4 Technique cluster & timeline

19.1 The brief & the angle

THE BRIEF

Buyer	B2C + B2B
Value prop	One flexible workspace for notes, docs, and databases.
THE single message	"Replace five tools with one canvas you shape yourself."
Angle shift	B2C: personal life OS → B2B: team wiki + project hub, single source of truth.

19.2 Brand kit & pace

BRAND KIT

Palette  #000000 ·  #37352F

Background	Clean white, faint borders
Typeface	Inter / system → Inter
Motion identity	Calm, blocky; drag-and-drop; modular
Music / BPM	Friendly productivity · 110-125
VO pace	2.4-2.6 words/sec
Tone words	calm, modular, clear

◆ BRAND NOTE

The signature move is the same data block flipping between views, board → calendar → table, with the records persisting as recognisable objects across the morph. Equal point counts on the morphing shapes or it tears.

19.3 The script

THE SCRIPT, TIMED, PRODUCTION-READY

[Hook · 0:00-0:04] "How many tabs are open right now? Be honest."

[Problem · 0:04-0:13] "Notes here, tasks there, the doc somewhere in Slack. Your brain has too many homes."

[Solution · 0:13-0:21] "Notion gives all of it one home you build yourself."

[Walkthrough · 0:21-0:46] "Type anywhere. Turn a line into a to-do, a page, a database. Drag a board into a calendar into a table, same data, any view. Link pages and your workspace starts to think with you."

[Benefits · 0:46-0:60] "So instead of switching tools, you stay in flow, one place for everything you know."

[CTA · 0:60-0:66] "Build your workspace. Start free."

19.4 Technique cluster & timeline

What this brand forces: Drag-and-drop with make-room motion (§11), block-to-database morph (§19 transitions), floating card stacks (§15), reveal-mask logo (§23).

SHOT-BY-SHOT TIMELINE, NOTION

TC	BEAT	ON-SCREEN (ELEMENTS)	AUDIO CUE	TRANSITION OUT
0:00-0:04	Hook	BG/ Notion + kinetic type (hook line)	music in (~110-125 BPM), riser	carry momentum into the problem
0:04-0:13	Problem	the messy status quo; spotlight on the chaos (§15)	low/tense ticks, rumble	match cut into the solution reveal
0:13-0:21	Solution	product UI reveal + logo reveal (reveal-mask)	hard pause (0.6s) → clean impact	camera push into the walkthrough
0:21-0:46	Walkthrough	the hero: one data block flips board → calendar → table, records persisting across the morph	per-action SFX; rising pitch on the hero move	object-continuous cut to benefits
0:46-0:60	Benefits	benefit lines as kinetic type + device/ browser mockup (§16)	warm music swell	mockup recedes; proof/logo fades up
0:60-0:66	CTA	reveal-mask logo lockup + shine sweep + CTA caption	final impact; music resolves	hold ~1.5s, fade to brand BG

⊖ LITMUS

Mute it, run it at 1.5×: does a stranger grasp *Replace five tools with one canvas you shape yourself*. from the visuals alone? If the hero move, one data block flips board → calendar → table, records persisting across the morph, doesn't read silent and sped-up, simplify the frame before you polish the keyframes.

TAKEAWAY

Notion is the same seven-beat skeleton tuned to a calm, modular, clear temperature: its kit, its pace, and one forced technique cluster carry the single message, "Replace five tools with one canvas you shape yourself.", from hook to CTA.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Real hex codes / fonts verified against the live brand
- ✓ One signature ease applied to every move
- ✓ The hero move reads muted at 1.5×
- ✓ Cuts on downbeats; key action on the stressed syllable
- ✓ Logo animation style matches brand energy



PART III • THE 18 BRAND STUDIES

20 Figma

“Design as a team sport, everyone in the same file.”, carried end to end: brief, kit, timed script, technique cluster, shot-by-shot timeline, and the assembly note.

SECTIONS

- 20.1 The brief & the angle
- 20.2 Brand kit & pace
- 20.3 The script
- 20.4 Technique cluster & timeline

20.1 The brief & the angle

THE BRIEF

Buyer	B2B (design/product)
Value prop	Design together in the browser, in real time.
THE single message	"Design as a team sport, everyone in the same file."
Angle shift	IC designer: powerful editor → Org: design-system governance at scale.

20.2 Brand kit & pace

BRAND KIT

Palette  #A259FF ·  #1ABCFE

Background	White canvas
Typeface	Whyte → Inter
Motion identity	Snappy, collaborative; cursors; vector morphs
Music / BPM	Friendly productivity · 110-125
VO pace	2.4-2.6 words/sec
Tone words	collaborative, snappy, precise

◆ BRAND NOTE

Multiple cursors moving at once is the whole brand idea, each cursor arcs and settles independently (offset the wiggle seeds). Build one cursor pre-comp, duplicate, recolor via the null, stagger the paths.

20.3 The script

THE SCRIPT, TIMED, PRODUCTION-READY

[Hook · 0:00-0:04] "Design used to mean exporting, emailing, and waiting."

[Problem · 0:04-0:12] "Versions multiplied. Feedback got lost. Nobody knew which file was real."

[Solution · 0:12-0:20] "Figma puts the whole team in one file, in the browser, live."

[Walkthrough · 0:20-0:46] "See everyone's cursor in real time. Comment right on the design. Build with components once, reuse them everywhere. And hand off to developers without exporting a thing."

[Benefits · 0:46-0:60] "So design stops being a relay race and becomes one conversation."

[CTA · 0:60-0:66] "Design together. Free to start."

20.4 Technique cluster & timeline

What this brand forces: Multiple live cursors (§11), component reuse / instance morphs (§19), comment pins, vector path morph (§19), the four-color brand.

SHOT-BY-SHOT TIMELINE, FIGMA

TC	BEAT	ON-SCREEN (ELEMENTS)	AUDIO CUE	TRANSITION OUT
0:00-0:04	Hook	BG/Figma + kinetic type (hook line)	music in (~110-125 BPM), riser	carry momentum into the problem
0:04-0:12	Problem	the messy status quo; spotlight on the chaos (§15)	low/tense ticks, rumble	match cut into the solution reveal
0:12-0:20	Solution	product UI reveal + logo reveal (build-from-parts)	hard pause (0.6s) → clean impact	camera push into the walkthrough
0:20-0:46	Walkthrough	the hero: multiple live cursors move at once; a component is reused; handoff with no export	per-action SFX; rising pitch on the hero move	object-continuous cut to benefits
0:46-0:60	Benefits	benefit lines as kinetic type + device/browser mockup (§16)	warm music swell	mockup recedes; proof/logo fades up
0:60-0:66	CTA	build-from-parts logo lockup + shine sweep + CTA caption	final impact; music resolves	hold ~1.5s, fade to brand BG

⊖ LITMUS

Mute it, run it at 1.5×: does a stranger grasp *Design as a team sport, everyone in the same file.* from the visuals alone? If the hero move, multiple live cursors move at once; a component is reused; handoff with no export, doesn't read silent and sped-up, simplify the frame before you polish the keyframes.

TAKEAWAY

Figma is the same seven-beat skeleton tuned to a collaborative, snappy, precise temperature: its kit, its pace, and one forced technique cluster carry the single message, "Design as a team sport, everyone in the same file.", from hook to CTA.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Real hex codes / fonts verified against the live brand
- ✓ One signature ease applied to every move
- ✓ The hero move reads muted at 1.5×
- ✓ Cuts on downbeats; key action on the stressed syllable
- ✓ Logo animation style matches brand energy



PART III • THE 18 BRAND STUDIES

21 Slack

“Your team's work happens in channels, not buried in inboxes.”, carried end to end: brief, kit, timed script, technique cluster, shot-by-shot timeline, and the assembly note.

SECTIONS

- 21.1 The brief & the angle
- 21.2 Brand kit & pace
- 21.3 The script
- 21.4 Technique cluster & timeline

21.1 The brief & the angle

THE BRIEF

Buyer	B2B
Value prop	Where work conversations and tools live in one place.
THE single message	"Your team's work happens in channels, not buried in inboxes."
Angle shift	SMB: simple chat → Enterprise: integrated workflow hub with automation.

21.2 Brand kit & pace

BRAND KIT

Palette	 #4A154B ·  #36C5F0
Background	White / aubergine sidebar
Typeface	Lato
Motion identity	Friendly bounce; notifications; emoji pops
Music / BPM	Friendly productivity · 110-125
VO pace	2.4-2.6 words/sec
Tone words	friendly, organised, light

◆ BRAND NOTE

The opener is a literal email-subject gag, lean into it. Notifications slide in with a soft pop and a bouncing count badge; the four secondary colors do the emoji/reaction work. The hash logo builds from parts with a tiny overshoot.

21.3 The script

THE SCRIPT, TIMED, PRODUCTION-READY

[Hook · 0:00-0:04] "Subject: RE: RE: RE: quick question."

[Problem · 0:04-0:12] "Email buries your work. The answer's in there, under forty replies."

[Solution · 0:12-0:20] "Slack moves work into channels, organized by what it's about."

[Walkthrough · 0:20-0:46] "Each project gets a channel. Pull in the tools you already use. Spin up a huddle to talk it out. And let automations handle the busywork while you focus."

[Benefits · 0:46-0:60] "So the right people see the right thing, and the answer's never buried again."

[CTA · 0:60-0:66] "Make work simpler. Try Slack free."

21.4 Technique cluster & timeline

What this brand forces: Notification slide-ins with count badges (§15), channel list build, automation spark (§13.4 variant), emoji pops, build-from-parts logo (§23).

SHOT-BY-SHOT TIMELINE, SLACK

TC	BEAT	ON-SCREEN (ELEMENTS)	AUDIO CUE	TRANSITION OUT
0:00-0:04	Hook	BG/Slack + kinetic type (hook line)	music in (~110-125 BPM), riser	carry momentum into the problem
0:04-0:12	Problem	the messy status quo; spotlight on the chaos (§15)	low/tense ticks, rumble	match cut into the solution reveal
0:12-0:20	Solution	product UI reveal + logo reveal (build-from-parts)	hard pause (0.6s) → clean impact	camera push into the walkthrough
0:20-0:46	Walkthrough	the hero: a channel fills; tools plug in; a huddle opens; an automation fires	per-action SFX; rising pitch on the hero move	object-continuous cut to benefits
0:46-0:60	Benefits	benefit lines as kinetic type + device/browser mockup (§16)	warm music swell	mockup recedes; proof/logo fades up
0:60-0:66	CTA	build-from-parts logo lockup + shine sweep + CTA caption	final impact; music resolves	hold ~1.5s, fade to brand BG

⊖ LITMUS

Mute it, run it at 1.5×: does a stranger grasp *Your team's work happens in channels, not buried in inboxes.* from the visuals alone? If the hero move, a channel fills; tools plug in; a huddle opens; an automation fires, doesn't read silent and sped-up, simplify the frame before you polish the keyframes.

TAKEAWAY

Slack is the same seven-beat skeleton tuned to a friendly, organised, light temperature: its kit, its pace, and one forced technique cluster carry the single message, “Your team’s work happens in channels, not buried in inboxes.”, from hook to CTA.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Real hex codes / fonts verified against the live brand
- ✓ One signature ease applied to every move
- ✓ The hero move reads muted at 1.5×
- ✓ Cuts on downbeats; key action on the stressed syllable
- ✓ Logo animation style matches brand energy



PART III • THE 18 BRAND STUDIES

22 Linear

“Software planning that feels as fast as you think.”, carried end to end: brief, kit, timed script, technique cluster, shot-by-shot timeline, and the assembly note.

SECTIONS

- 22.1 The brief & the angle
- 22.2 Brand kit & pace
- 22.3 The script
- 22.4 Technique cluster & timeline

22.1 The brief & the angle

THE BRIEF

Buyer	B2B (eng teams)
Value prop	Issue tracking built for speed and focus.
THE single message	"Software planning that feels as fast as you think."
Angle shift	IC dev: keyboard-fast → Eng leader: roadmap clarity and velocity insight.

22.2 Brand kit & pace

BRAND KIT

Palette	 #5E6AD2 ·  #5E6AD2
Background	Dark, deep; near-black #08090A
Typeface	Inter
Motion identity	Fast, crisp; snap cuts; subtle glows
Music / BPM	Confident tech · 100-120
VO pace	2.4-2.6 words/sec
Tone words	fast, crisp, focused

◆ BRAND NOTE

Speed is the brand, so the editing is the craft: snap cuts (zero-overlap on the Cmd-K beat only, an exception to the overlap rule, used deliberately), 8-10 frame moves, no overshoot, a faint indigo glow on near-black. The roadmap re-flowing itself is the hero frame.

22.3 The script

THE SCRIPT, TIMED, PRODUCTION-READY

[Hook · 0:00-0:04] "Your tools shouldn't be slower than your team."

[Problem · 0:04-0:12] "Most issue trackers are heavy, cluttered, and built for managing, not building."

[Solution · 0:12-0:20] "Linear is planning software that moves at the speed of thought."

[Walkthrough · 0:20-0:46] "Hit Cmd-K and do anything in a keystroke. Create an issue, assign it, ship it through your cycle. Watch the roadmap update itself as work moves."

[Benefits · 0:46-0:60] "So your team spends time building, not fighting the tool that tracks the building."

[CTA · 0:60-0:66] "Move faster. Try Linear."

22.4 Technique cluster & timeline

What this brand forces: Snap cuts on Cmd-K (§19), command-palette type-on (§12), self-updating roadmap, subtle glow on dark (§16), no-overshoot ease.

SHOT-BY-SHOT TIMELINE, LINEAR

TC	BEAT	ON-SCREEN (ELEMENTS)	AUDIO CUE	TRANSITION OUT
0:00-0:04	Hook	BG/ Linear + kinetic type (hook line)	music in (~100-120 BPM), riser	carry momentum into the problem
0:04-0:12	Problem	the messy status quo; spotlight on the chaos (§15)	low/tense ticks, rumble	match cut into the solution reveal
0:12-0:20	Solution	product UI reveal + logo reveal (draw-on)	hard pause (0.6s) → clean impact	camera push into the walkthrough
0:20-0:46	Walkthrough	the hero: Cmd-K snap- opens; an issue ships through a cycle; the roadmap re-flows itself	per-action SFX; rising pitch on the hero move	object-continuous cut to benefits
0:46-0:60	Benefits	benefit lines as kinetic type + device/ browser mockup (§16)	warm music swell	mockup recedes; proof/logo fades up
0:60-0:66	CTA	draw-on logo lockup + shine sweep + CTA caption	final impact; music resolves	hold ~1.5s, fade to brand BG

⊖ LITMUS

Mute it, run it at 1.5×: does a stranger grasp *Software planning that feels as fast as you think.* from the visuals alone? If the hero move, Cmd-K snap-opens; an issue ships through a cycle; the roadmap re-flows itself, doesn't read silent and sped-up, simplify the frame before you polish the keyframes.

TAKEAWAY

Linear is the same seven-beat skeleton tuned to a fast, crisp, focused temperature: its kit, its pace, and one forced technique cluster carry the single message, "Software planning that feels as fast as you think.", from hook to CTA.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Real hex codes / fonts verified against the live brand
- ✓ One signature ease applied to every move
- ✓ The hero move reads muted at 1.5×
- ✓ Cuts on downbeats; key action on the stressed syllable
- ✓ Logo animation style matches brand energy



PART III • THE 18 BRAND STUDIES

23 Spotify

“The soundtrack to your day, already knows what's next.”, carried end to end: brief, kit, timed script, technique cluster, shot-by-shot timeline, and the assembly note.

SECTIONS

- 23.1 The brief & the angle
- 23.2 Brand kit & pace
- 23.3 The script
- 23.4 Technique cluster & timeline

23.1 The brief & the angle

THE BRIEF

Buyer	B2C
Value prop	Every song, podcast, and mood, instantly.
THE single message	"The soundtrack to your day, already knows what's next."
Angle shift	Listener: discovery / vibe → Spotify for Artists: reach and royalty insight.

23.2 Brand kit & pace

BRAND KIT

Palette	 #1DB954 ·  #191414
Background	Black, bold color blocks
Typeface	Spotify Circular → Montserrat / Poppins
Motion identity	Beat-reactive; bold; energetic
Music / BPM	Upbeat consumer · 120-130
VO pace	2.6-2.9 words/sec
Tone words	energetic, bold, personal

◆ BRAND NOTE

This is the one video where the music leads everything, convert audio to keyframes and drive cover-art scale off the kick. Whip cuts on the beat, bold full-frame color blocks per playlist mood. The fastest VO in the book.

23.3 The script

THE SCRIPT, TIMED, PRODUCTION-READY

[Hook · 0:00-0:03] "Press play. The rest is handled."

[Problem · 0:03-0:10] "Too much music, no time to dig. You just want it to match the moment."

[Solution · 0:10-0:18] "Spotify learns your taste and reads the room."

[Walkthrough · 0:18-0:42] "Your Daily Mixes, ready every morning. A playlist for the run, the focus, the wind-down. And Discover Weekly, thirty songs you've never heard, that somehow feel like you."

[Benefits · 0:42-0:55] "So whatever you're doing, the soundtrack's already on."

[CTA · 0:55-0:60] "Your sound. Press play free."

23.4 Technique cluster & timeline

What this brand forces: Audio-amplitude-driven scale (§16 beat-sync), whip cuts (§19), bold color-block transitions, particle/streak atmosphere (§16), counting streams (§13).

SHOT-BY-SHOT TIMELINE, SPOTIFY

TC	BEAT	ON-SCREEN (ELEMENTS)	AUDIO CUE	TRANSITION OUT
0:00-0:03	Hook	BG/ Spotify + kinetic type (hook line)	music in (~120-130 BPM), riser	carry momentum into the problem
0:03-0:10	Problem	the messy status quo; spotlight on the chaos (§15)	low/tense ticks, rumble	match cut into the solution reveal
0:10-0:18	Solution	product UI reveal + logo reveal (draw-on)	hard pause (0.6s) → clean impact	camera push into the walkthrough
0:18-0:42	Walkthrough	the hero: cover art scales on the kick; mood color- blocks whip past; Discover Weekly resolves	per-action SFX; rising pitch on the hero move	object-continuous cut to benefits
0:42-0:55	Benefits	benefit lines as kinetic type + device/ browser mockup (§16)	warm music swell	mockup recedes; proof/logo fades up
0:55-0:60	CTA	draw-on logo lockup + shine sweep + CTA caption	final impact; music resolves	hold ~1.5s, fade to brand BG

⊖ LITMUS

Mute it, run it at 1.5×: does a stranger grasp *The soundtrack to your day, already knows what's next.* from the visuals alone? If the hero move, cover art scales on the kick; mood color-blocks whip past; Discover Weekly resolves, doesn't read silent and sped-up, simplify the frame before you polish the keyframes.

TAKEAWAY

Spotify is the same seven-beat skeleton tuned to a energetic, bold, personal temperature: its kit, its pace, and one forced technique cluster carry the single message, "The soundtrack to your day, already knows what's next.", from hook to CTA.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Real hex codes / fonts verified against the live brand
- ✓ One signature ease applied to every move
- ✓ The hero move reads muted at 1.5×
- ✓ Cuts on downbeats; key action on the stressed syllable
- ✓ Logo animation style matches brand energy



PART III • THE 18 BRAND STUDIES

24 Canva

“Anyone can make it look designed.”, carried end to end: brief, kit, timed script, technique cluster, shot-by-shot timeline, and the assembly note.

SECTIONS

- 24.1 The brief & the angle
- 24.2 Brand kit & pace
- 24.3 The script
- 24.4 Technique cluster & timeline

24.1 The brief & the angle

THE BRIEF

Buyer	B2C + B2B (SMB)
Value prop	Professional design without being a designer.
THE single message	"Anyone can make it look designed."
Angle shift	Solo creator: speed / templates → Teams: brand kit + on-brand at scale.

24.2 Brand kit & pace

BRAND KIT

Palette	 #00C4CC ·  #7D2AE8
Background	White, colorful
Typeface	Canva Sans → Poppins
Motion identity	Bouncy; drag/drop; playful pops
Music / BPM	Upbeat consumer · 120-130
VO pace	2.6-2.9 words/sec
Tone words	approachable, bright, fast

◆ BRAND NOTE

The magic beat is one-click resize, a single design re-flowing from a square post to a story to a banner. Build it as a responsive morph: same elements, re-stacked. Bouncy overshoot is on-brand here (unlike Stripe).

24.3 The script

THE SCRIPT, TIMED, PRODUCTION-READY

[Hook · 0:00-0:04] "You have ten minutes and zero design skills. Go."

[Problem · 0:04-0:12] "Real design tools are powerful, and a wall you don't have time to climb."

[Solution · 0:12-0:20] "Canva starts you on a template that already looks great."

[Walkthrough · 0:20-0:46] "Pick a design, swap the text, drag in a photo. Resize it for every platform in one click. And keep your brand colors and fonts one tap away."

[Benefits · 0:46-0:60] "So in minutes, you've made something that looks like a designer made it."

[CTA · 0:60-0:66] "Design anything. Start free."

24.4 Technique cluster & timeline

What this brand forces: Template swap morphs (§19), drag-drop (§11), one-click resize (responsive morph, §19), before/after split, bouncy ease, gradient brand.

SHOT-BY-SHOT TIMELINE, CANVA

TC	BEAT	ON-SCREEN (ELEMENTS)	AUDIO CUE	TRANSITION OUT
0:00-0:04	Hook	BG/Canva + kinetic type (hook line)	music in (~120-130 BPM), riser	carry momentum into the problem
0:04-0:12	Problem	the messy status quo; spotlight on the chaos (§15)	low/tense ticks, rumble	match cut into the solution reveal
0:12-0:20	Solution	product UI reveal + logo reveal (draw-on)	hard pause (0.6s) → clean impact	camera push into the walkthrough
0:20-0:46	Walkthrough	the hero: a template's text swaps, a photo drags in, and one click resizes it across formats	per-action SFX; rising pitch on the hero move	object-continuous cut to benefits
0:46-0:60	Benefits	benefit lines as kinetic type + device/browser mockup (§16)	warm music swell	mockup recedes; proof/logo fades up
0:60-0:66	CTA	draw-on logo lockup + shine sweep + CTA caption	final impact; music resolves	hold ~1.5s, fade to brand BG

⊖ LITMUS

Mute it, run it at 1.5×: does a stranger grasp *Anyone can make it look designed.* from the visuals alone? If the hero move, a template's text swaps, a photo drags in, and one click resizes it across formats, doesn't read silent and sped-up, simplify the frame before you polish the keyframes.

TAKEAWAY

Canva is the same seven-beat skeleton tuned to a approachable, bright, fast temperature: its kit, its pace, and one forced technique cluster carry the single message, “Anyone can make it look designed.”, from hook to CTA.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Real hex codes / fonts verified against the live brand
- ✓ One signature ease applied to every move
- ✓ The hero move reads muted at 1.5×
- ✓ Cuts on downbeats; key action on the stressed syllable
- ✓ Logo animation style matches brand energy



PART III • THE 18 BRAND STUDIES

25 Loom

“Say it once on video instead of a meeting that didn't need to happen.”, carried end to end: brief, kit, timed script, technique cluster, shot-by-shot timeline, and the assembly note.

SECTIONS

- 25.1 The brief & the angle
- 25.2 Brand kit & pace
- 25.3 The script
- 25.4 Technique cluster & timeline

25.1 The brief & the angle

THE BRIEF

Buyer	B2B
Value prop	Record your screen and talk, share async in seconds.
THE single message	"Say it once on video instead of a meeting that didn't need to happen."
Angle shift	IC: quick share → Org: async culture, fewer meetings, faster onboarding.

25.2 Brand kit & pace

BRAND KIT

Palette	 #625DF5 ·  #FF6C5C
Background	White / soft purple
Typeface	Inter
Motion identity	Quick, casual; record pulse; bubble cam
Music / BPM	Friendly productivity · 110-125
VO pace	2.4-2.6 words/sec
Tone words	casual, quick, human

◆ BRAND NOTE

The record-pulse ring (looping Scale 100→180, Opacity 100→0, ~1.2s) and the circular bubble-cam in the corner are the two instantly-readable Loom signals. Keep it casual, this brand is anti-polish, so the ease is gentle, not snappy.

25.3 The script

THE SCRIPT, TIMED, PRODUCTION-READY

[Hook · 0:00-0:04] "This meeting could've been a Loom."

[Problem · 0:04-0:12] "Explaining something over text takes paragraphs. Scheduling a call takes days."

[Solution · 0:12-0:20] "Loom records your screen and your voice, and shares in seconds."

[Walkthrough · 0:20-0:44] "Hit record. Walk through it while they watch your screen and see your face. Send a link, they watch on their time, at their speed, and reply right on the video."

[Benefits · 0:44-0:58] "So you say it once, clearly, and skip the meeting that didn't need to happen."

[CTA · 0:58-0:64] "Record your first Loom free."

25.4 Technique cluster & timeline

What this brand forces: Record-pulse indicator (§15 looping ring), bubble-cam (masked circle), captured-footage treatment (§11), link/share moment, casual ease.

SHOT-BY-SHOT TIMELINE, LOOM

TC	BEAT	ON-SCREEN (ELEMENTS)	AUDIO CUE	TRANSITION OUT
0:00-0:04	Hook	BG/Loom + kinetic type (hook line)	music in (~110-125 BPM), riser	carry momentum into the problem
0:04-0:12	Problem	the messy status quo; spotlight on the chaos (§15)	low/tense ticks, rumble	match cut into the solution reveal
0:12-0:20	Solution	product UI reveal + logo reveal (draw-on)	hard pause (0.6s) → clean impact	camera push into the walkthrough
0:20-0:44	Walkthrough	the hero: the record- pulse ring fires; a bubble- cam rolls; a share link sends	per-action SFX; rising pitch on the hero move	object-continuous cut to benefits
0:44-0:58	Benefits	benefit lines as kinetic type + device/ browser mockup (§16)	warm music swell	mockup recedes; proof/logo fades up
0:58-0:64	CTA	draw-on logo lockup + shine sweep + CTA caption	final impact; music resolves	hold ~1.5s, fade to brand BG

⊖ LITMUS

Mute it, run it at 1.5×: does a stranger grasp *Say it once on video instead of a meeting that didn't need to happen.* from the visuals alone? If the hero move, the record-pulse ring fires; a bubble-cam rolls; a share link sends, doesn't read silent and sped-up, simplify the frame before you polish the keyframes.

TAKEAWAY

Loom is the same seven-beat skeleton tuned to a casual, quick, human temperature: its kit, its pace, and one forced technique cluster carry the single message, “Say it once on video instead of a meeting that didn't need to happen.”, from hook to CTA.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Real hex codes / fonts verified against the live brand
- ✓ One signature ease applied to every move
- ✓ The hero move reads muted at 1.5×
- ✓ Cuts on downbeats; key action on the stressed syllable
- ✓ Logo animation style matches brand energy



PART III • THE 18 BRAND STUDIES

26 Airtable

“Your data, shaped into any view your team needs.”, carried end to end: brief, kit, timed script, technique cluster, shot-by-shot timeline, and the assembly note.

SECTIONS

- 26.1 The brief & the angle
- 26.2 Brand kit & pace
- 26.3 The script
- 26.4 Technique cluster & timeline

26.1 The brief & the angle

THE BRIEF

Buyer	B2B
Value prop	A database that feels as easy as a spreadsheet.
THE single message	"Your data, shaped into any view your team needs."
Angle shift	Builder: flexible base → Ops leader: connected apps and workflows.

26.2 Brand kit & pace

BRAND KIT

Palette	 #2D7FF9 ·  #FCB400
Background	White, colored cells
Typeface	Inter
Motion identity	Data morphs; grid→view; colorful records
Music / BPM	Friendly productivity · 110-125
VO pace	2.4-2.6 words/sec
Tone words	flexible, colorful, capable

◆ BRAND NOTE

The same colored records persisting as they flip grid → kanban → calendar → gallery is the entire pitch. Keep each record a recognisable colored chip across every view so the eye tracks "same data, new shape."

26.3 The script

THE SCRIPT, TIMED, PRODUCTION-READY

[Hook · 0:00-0:04] "It started as a spreadsheet. It became your whole operation."

[Problem · 0:04-0:13] "Spreadsheets break when real teams and real workflows pile on."

[Solution · 0:13-0:21] "Airtable is a database with a spreadsheet's friendly face."

[Walkthrough · 0:21-0:46] "Start with rows you understand. Flip the same data into a kanban, a calendar, a gallery. Link records across tables. Then automate the parts you keep doing by hand."

[Benefits · 0:46-0:60] "So your team builds the exact tool it needs, without writing code."

[CTA · 0:60-0:66] "Build your base. Start free."

26.4 Technique cluster & timeline

What this brand forces: Grid→kanban→calendar→gallery morph (§19), colored record cells, linked-record connection lines (§13.4 pipeline variant), automation spark, counting.

SHOT-BY-SHOT TIMELINE, AIRTABLE

TC	BEAT	ON-SCREEN (ELEMENTS)	AUDIO CUE	TRANSITION OUT
0:00-0:04	Hook	BG/ Airtable + kinetic type (hook line)	music in (~110-125 BPM), riser	carry momentum into the problem
0:04-0:13	Problem	the messy status quo; spotlight on the chaos (§15)	low/tense ticks, rumble	match cut into the solution reveal
0:13-0:21	Solution	product UI reveal + logo reveal (build- from- parts)	hard pause (0.6s) → clean impact	camera push into the walkthrough
0:21-0:46	Walkthrough	the hero: the same colored records flip grid → kanban → calendar → gallery	per-action SFX; rising pitch on the hero move	object-continuous cut to benefits
0:46-0:60	Benefits	benefit lines as kinetic type + device/ browser mockup (§16)	warm music swell	mockup recedes; proof/logo fades up
0:60-0:66	CTA	build-from- parts logo lockup + shine sweep + CTA caption	final impact; music resolves	hold ~1.5s, fade to brand BG

⊖ LITMUS

Mute it, run it at 1.5×: does a stranger grasp *Your data, shaped into any view your team needs.* from the visuals alone? If the hero move, the same colored records flip grid → kanban → calendar → gallery, doesn't read silent and sped-up, simplify the frame before you polish the keyframes.

TAKEAWAY

Airtable is the same seven-beat skeleton tuned to a flexible, colorful, capable temperature: its kit, its pace, and one forced technique cluster carry the single message, "Your data, shaped into any view your team needs.", from hook to CTA.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Real hex codes / fonts verified against the live brand
- ✓ One signature ease applied to every move
- ✓ The hero move reads muted at 1.5×
- ✓ Cuts on downbeats; key action on the stressed syllable
- ✓ Logo animation style matches brand energy



PART III • THE 18 BRAND STUDIES

27 Duolingo

“Tiny daily wins make a new language stick.”, carried end to end: brief, kit, timed script, technique cluster, shot-by-shot timeline, and the assembly note.

SECTIONS

- 27.1 The brief & the angle
- 27.2 Brand kit & pace
- 27.3 The script
- 27.4 Technique cluster & timeline

27.1 The brief & the angle

THE BRIEF

Buyer	B2C
Value prop	Learn a language in a few fun minutes a day.
THE single message	"Tiny daily wins make a new language stick."
Angle shift	Learner: fun / streaks → Schools: measurable progress.

27.2 Brand kit & pace

BRAND KIT

Palette	 #58CC02 ·  #1CB0F6
Background	White, rounded
Typeface	Feather Bold / din-round → Nunito (rounded)
Motion identity	Squash-and-stretch; bouncy; character-led
Music / BPM	Playful · 115-130
VO pace	2.6-2.9 words/sec
Tone words	playful, bouncy, encouraging

◆ BRAND NOTE

The most character-led video in the set, Duo carries it. Full squash-and-stretch and overlapping action on every move; the notification gag ("Duo will remind you") is the comedic beat. Everything overshoots and bounces; this is the opposite end of the dial from Claude/Stripe.

27.3 The script

THE SCRIPT, TIMED, PRODUCTION-READY

[Hook · 0:00-0:04] "You've 'always wanted to learn a language.' Today's the day."

[Problem · 0:04-0:12] "Classes are slow, apps are boring, and motivation fades by week two."

[Solution · 0:12-0:20] "Duolingo turns learning into a game you actually want to keep playing."

[Walkthrough · 0:20-0:44] "Bite-size lessons, just a few minutes. Earn XP, level up, keep your streak alive. And yes, Duo will absolutely remind you."

[Benefits · 0:44-0:58] "So a new language stops being a someday goal and becomes a daily habit."

[CTA · 0:58-0:64] "Start your streak. Free, forever."

27.4 Technique cluster & timeline

What this brand forces: Character squash-and-stretch (§10), streak-flame, XP counting numbers (§13), goal/progress ring (§13.4 variant), notification gag, build-from-parts bouncy logo (§23).

SHOT-BY-SHOT TIMELINE, DUOLINGO

TC	BEAT	ON-SCREEN (ELEMENTS)	AUDIO CUE	TRANSITION OUT
0:00-0:04	Hook	BG/ Duolingo + kinetic type (hook line)	music in (~115-130 BPM), riser	carry momentum into the problem
0:04-0:12	Problem	the messy status quo; spotlight on the chaos (§15)	low/tense ticks, rumble	match cut into the solution reveal
0:12-0:20	Solution	product UI reveal + logo reveal (build- from- parts)	hard pause (0.6s) → clean impact	camera push into the walkthrough
0:20-0:44	Walkthrough	the hero: Duo bounces through a lesson; XP counts up; the streak flame lights; a nudge pops	per-action SFX; rising pitch on the hero move	object-continuous cut to benefits
0:44-0:58	Benefits	benefit lines as kinetic type + device/ browser mockup (§16)	warm music swell	mockup recedes; proof/logo fades up
0:58-0:64	CTA	build-from- parts logo lockup + shine sweep + CTA caption	final impact; music resolves	hold ~1.5s, fade to brand BG

⊖ LITMUS

Mute it, run it at 1.5×: does a stranger grasp *Tiny daily wins make a new language stick*. from the visuals alone? If the hero move, Duo bounces through a lesson; XP counts up; the streak flame lights; a nudge pops, doesn't read silent and sped-up, simplify the frame before you polish the keyframes.

TAKEAWAY

Duolingo is the same seven-beat skeleton tuned to a playful, bouncy, encouraging temperature: its kit, its pace, and one forced technique cluster carry the single message, "Tiny daily wins make a new language stick.", from hook to CTA.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Real hex codes / fonts verified against the live brand
- ✓ One signature ease applied to every move
- ✓ The hero move reads muted at 1.5×
- ✓ Cuts on downbeats; key action on the stressed syllable
- ✓ Logo animation style matches brand energy



PART III • THE 18 BRAND STUDIES

28 Grammarly

“Sound clear and confident in every message.”, carried end to end: brief, kit, timed script, technique cluster, shot-by-shot timeline, and the assembly note.

SECTIONS

- 28.1 The brief & the angle
- 28.2 Brand kit & pace
- 28.3 The script
- 28.4 Technique cluster & timeline

28.1 The brief & the angle

THE BRIEF

Buyer	B2C + B2B
Value prop	Writing help that works wherever you type.
THE single message	"Sound clear and confident in every message."
Angle shift	Individual: fewer mistakes → Org: consistent, on-brand, secure comms.

28.2 Brand kit & pace

BRAND KIT

Palette	 #15C39A ·  #1B1B27
Background	White
Typeface	Gerstner / system → Inter
Motion identity	Inline reveals; underline draws; tooltips
Music / BPM	Friendly productivity · 110-125
VO pace	2.4-2.6 words/sec
Tone words	sharp, reassuring, clear

◆ BRAND NOTE

The underline-draw (a trim-path on a hand-drawn squiggle) and the suggestion tooltip popping from its pointer corner are the two micro-moments. Show the before/after rewrite as a split so the improvement is visible muted.

28.3 The script

THE SCRIPT, TIMED, PRODUCTION-READY

[Hook · 0:00-0:04] "You hit send. Then you spot the typo."

[Problem · 0:04-0:12] "Every email, doc, and message is a chance to sound less sharp than you are."

[Solution · 0:12-0:20] "Grammarly checks your writing everywhere you type."

[Walkthrough · 0:20-0:44] "Watch the underline appear. One click fixes it. It sharpens your tone, trims the clutter, and rewrites the line you couldn't get right."

[Benefits · 0:44-0:58] "So you sound clear and confident, before you hit send, not after."

[CTA · 0:58-0:64] "Write better today. Add it free."

28.4 Technique cluster & timeline

What this brand forces: Underline draw-on (§13 trim-path on a squiggle), suggestion tooltips (§15), one-click before/after rewrite (split-screen §19), typing UI (§12).

SHOT-BY-SHOT TIMELINE, GRAMMARLY

TC	BEAT	ON-SCREEN (ELEMENTS)	AUDIO CUE	TRANSITION OUT
0:00-0:04	Hook	BG/ Grammarly + kinetic type (hook line)	music in (~110-125 BPM), riser	carry momentum into the problem
0:04-0:12	Problem	the messy status quo; spotlight on the chaos (§15)	low/tense ticks, rumble	match cut into the solution reveal
0:12-0:20	Solution	product UI reveal + logo reveal (draw-on)	hard pause (0.6s) → clean impact	camera push into the walkthrough
0:20-0:44	Walkthrough	the hero: an underline draws on; a suggestion tooltip pops; a before/ after rewrite splits	per-action SFX; rising pitch on the hero move	object-continuous cut to benefits
0:44-0:58	Benefits	benefit lines as kinetic type + device/ browser mockup (§16)	warm music swell	mockup recedes; proof/logo fades up
0:58-0:64	CTA	draw-on logo lockup + shine sweep + CTA caption	final impact; music resolves	hold ~1.5s, fade to brand BG

⊖ LITMUS

Mute it, run it at 1.5×: does a stranger grasp *Sound clear and confident in every message.* from the visuals alone? If the hero move, an underline draws on; a suggestion tooltip pops; a before/after rewrite splits, doesn't read silent and sped-up, simplify the frame before you polish the keyframes.

TAKEAWAY

Grammarly is the same seven-beat skeleton tuned to a sharp, reassuring, clear temperature: its kit, its pace, and one forced technique cluster carry the single message, “Sound clear and confident in every message.”, from hook to CTA.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Real hex codes / fonts verified against the live brand
- ✓ One signature ease applied to every move
- ✓ The hero move reads muted at 1.5×
- ✓ Cuts on downbeats; key action on the stressed syllable
- ✓ Logo animation style matches brand energy



PART III • THE 18 BRAND STUDIES

29 Calendly

“Share a link, skip the 'does Tuesday work?' thread.”, carried end to end: brief, kit, timed script, technique cluster, shot-by-shot timeline, and the assembly note.

SECTIONS

- 29.1 The brief & the angle
- 29.2 Brand kit & pace
- 29.3 The script
- 29.4 Technique cluster & timeline

29.1 The brief & the angle

THE BRIEF

Buyer	B2B + prosumer
Value prop	Scheduling without the back-and-forth emails.
THE single message	"Share a link, skip the 'does Tuesday work?' thread."
Angle shift	Solo: easy booking → Teams: routing, round-robin, CRM-connected pipelines.

29.2 Brand kit & pace

BRAND KIT

Palette	 #006BFF ·  #0A2540
Background	White
Typeface	Inter / Circular → Inter
Motion identity	Clean; calendar fills; booking flow
Music / BPM	Friendly productivity · 110-125
VO pace	2.4-2.6 words/sec
Tone words	clean, effortless, reliable

◆ BRAND NOTE

The email-thread gag opens it (kinetic type, overlapping replies). The hero is the available slots filling in and the two calendars syncing, a success-state check seals it. Clean and quick, no bounce.

29.3 The script

THE SCRIPT, TIMED, PRODUCTION-READY

[Hook · 0:00-0:04] "'Does Tuesday work? How about Thursday? Actually, '"

[Problem · 0:04-0:12] "Booking one meeting can cost a dozen emails and three time zones of confusion."

[Solution · 0:12-0:20] "Calendly turns all that into a single link."

[Walkthrough · 0:20-0:42] "Set your availability once. Share your link. They pick a time that's actually free, and it's on both calendars, invite sent, done."

[Benefits · 0:42-0:56] "So scheduling stops being a chore and starts being a click."

[CTA · 0:56-0:62] "Share your link. Sign up free."

29.4 Technique cluster & timeline

What this brand forces: Calendar slot-fill (staggered cell reveal), link-share moment, round-robin routing (automation spark §13.4), confirmation success-state (§15), clean ease.

SHOT-BY-SHOT TIMELINE, CALENDLY

TC	BEAT	ON-SCREEN (ELEMENTS)	AUDIO CUE	TRANSITION OUT
0:00-0:04	Hook	BG/ Calendly + kinetic type (hook line)	music in (~110-125 BPM), riser	carry momentum into the problem
0:04-0:12	Problem	the messy status quo; spotlight on the chaos (§15)	low/tense ticks, rumble	match cut into the solution reveal
0:12-0:20	Solution	product UI reveal + logo reveal (draw-on)	hard pause (0.6s) → clean impact	camera push into the walkthrough
0:20-0:42	Walkthrough	the hero: availability sets, slots fill, a link shares, both calendars sync with a check	per-action SFX; rising pitch on the hero move	object-continuous cut to benefits
0:42-0:56	Benefits	benefit lines as kinetic type + device/ browser mockup (§16)	warm music swell	mockup recedes; proof/logo fades up
0:56-0:62	CTA	draw-on logo lockup + shine sweep + CTA caption	final impact; music resolves	hold ~1.5s, fade to brand BG

⊖ LITMUS

Mute it, run it at 1.5×: does a stranger grasp *Share a link, skip the 'does Tuesday work?' thread.* from the visuals alone? If the hero move, availability sets, slots fill, a link shares, both calendars sync with a check, doesn't read silent and sped-up, simplify the frame before you polish the keyframes.

TAKEAWAY

Calendly is the same seven-beat skeleton tuned to a clean, effortless, reliable temperature: its kit, its pace, and one forced technique cluster carry the single message, “Share a link, skip the ‘does Tuesday work?’ thread.”, from hook to CTA.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Real hex codes / fonts verified against the live brand
- ✓ One signature ease applied to every move
- ✓ The hero move reads muted at 1.5×
- ✓ Cuts on downbeats; key action on the stressed syllable
- ✓ Logo animation style matches brand energy



PART III • THE 18 BRAND STUDIES

30 Webflow

“Design it visually, ship production-grade code.”, carried end to end: brief, kit, timed script, technique cluster, shot-by-shot timeline, and the assembly note.

SECTIONS

- 30.1 The brief & the angle
- 30.2 Brand kit & pace
- 30.3 The script
- 30.4 Technique cluster & timeline

30.1 The brief & the angle

THE BRIEF

Buyer	B2B (design/marketing)
Value prop	Build responsive websites visually, no code.
THE single message	"Design it visually, ship production-grade code."
Angle shift	Designer: creative control → Marketing team: launch and edit without devs.

30.2 Brand kit & pace

BRAND KIT

Palette  #4353FF ·  #080808

Background	Dark or white
Typeface	Inter
Motion identity	Responsive resize; breakpoint morphs
Music / BPM	Confident tech · 100-120
VO pace	2.4-2.6 words/sec
Tone words	powerful, visual, production-grade

◆ BRAND NOTE

The breakpoint reflow (one layout snapping cleanly between desktop, tablet, and phone frames) is the signature. End on the design literally becoming code, then a one-click publish success-state.

30.3 The script

THE SCRIPT, TIMED, PRODUCTION-READY

[Hook · 0:00-0:04] "Designers imagine it. Then wait months for someone to build it."

[Problem · 0:04-0:12] "The gap between design and code is where great sites go to die."

[Solution · 0:12-0:20] "Webflow lets you design and ship a real site, visually."

[Walkthrough · 0:20-0:46] "Style every element on a canvas. Watch it respond across desktop, tablet, and phone. Add real interactions without a line of code. And publish to production in a click."

[Benefits · 0:46-0:60] "So your vision goes live exactly as designed, no translation lost."

[CTA · 0:60-0:66] "Build it visually. Start free."

30.4 Technique cluster & timeline

What this brand forces: Breakpoint morph (desktop→tablet→phone responsive reflow §19), style-panel edits, design→code reveal, publish success-state, browser mockup (§22).

SHOT-BY-SHOT TIMELINE, WEBFLOW

TC	BEAT	ON-SCREEN (ELEMENTS)	AUDIO CUE	TRANSITION OUT
0:00-0:04	Hook	BG/ Webflow + kinetic type (hook line)	music in (~100-120 BPM), riser	carry momentum into the problem
0:04-0:12	Problem	the messy status quo; spotlight on the chaos (§15)	low/tense ticks, rumble	match cut into the solution reveal
0:12-0:20	Solution	product UI reveal + logo reveal (draw-on)	hard pause (0.6s) → clean impact	camera push into the walkthrough
0:20-0:46	Walkthrough	the hero: the layout reflows desktop → tablet → phone, then design becomes code and publishes	per-action SFX; rising pitch on the hero move	object-continuous cut to benefits
0:46-0:60	Benefits	benefit lines as kinetic type + device/ browser mockup (§16)	warm music swell	mockup recedes; proof/logo fades up
0:60-0:66	CTA	draw-on logo lockup + shine sweep + CTA caption	final impact; music resolves	hold ~1.5s, fade to brand BG

⊖ LITMUS

Mute it, run it at 1.5×: does a stranger grasp *Design it visually, ship production-grade code.* from the visuals alone? If the hero move, the layout reflows desktop → tablet → phone, then design becomes code and publishes, doesn't read silent and sped-up, simplify the frame before you polish the keyframes.

TAKEAWAY

Webflow is the same seven-beat skeleton tuned to a powerful, visual, production-grade temperature: its kit, its pace, and one forced technique cluster carry the single message, “Design it visually, ship production-grade code.”, from hook to CTA.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Real hex codes / fonts verified against the live brand
- ✓ One signature ease applied to every move
- ✓ The hero move reads muted at 1.5×
- ✓ Cuts on downbeats; key action on the stressed syllable
- ✓ Logo animation style matches brand energy



PART III • THE 18 BRAND STUDIES

31 Miro

“Every idea, on one endless canvas the whole team can see.”, carried end to end: brief, kit, timed script, technique cluster, shot-by-shot timeline, and the assembly note.

SECTIONS

- 31.1 The brief & the angle
- 31.2 Brand kit & pace
- 31.3 The script
- 31.4 Technique cluster & timeline

31.1 The brief & the angle

THE BRIEF

Buyer	B2B
Value prop	An infinite whiteboard for teams to think together.
THE single message	"Every idea, on one endless canvas the whole team can see."
Angle shift	Facilitator: workshops → Org: persistent visual collaboration across teams.

31.2 Brand kit & pace

BRAND KIT

Palette	 #FFD02F ·  #050038
Background	Light gray canvas
Typeface	Inter
Motion identity	Infinite zoom; parallax; sticky physics
Music / BPM	Friendly productivity · 110-125
VO pace	2.4-2.6 words/sec
Tone words	expansive, collaborative, kinetic

◆ BRAND NOTE

The zoom-out reveal, one sticky becoming a vast board, is the whole idea, and it needs the Z-separated camera rig for true parallax. Sticky notes land with a tiny squash. Many cursors move at once, like Figma but busier.

31.3 The script

THE SCRIPT, TIMED, PRODUCTION-READY

[Hook · 0:00-0:04] "The best ideas don't fit on one screen."

[Problem · 0:04-0:12] "Remote teams lost the whiteboard, and the messy magic that happens around it."

[Solution · 0:12-0:20] "Miro is an infinite canvas the whole team shares."

[Walkthrough · 0:20-0:44] "Drop a sticky, zoom out, and see the whole map. Run a workshop with everyone's cursor moving at once. Turn the mess into a plan, right where you made it."

[Benefits · 0:44-0:58] "So distance stops mattering, you're all thinking on the same wall again."

[CTA · 0:58-0:64] "Start your board. Free to try."

31.4 Technique cluster & timeline

What this brand forces: Infinite-canvas zoom-out (camera §14), parallax depth, sticky-note physics (squash on drop), many live cursors (§11), seamless-loop pan.

SHOT-BY-SHOT TIMELINE, MIRO

TC	BEAT	ON-SCREEN (ELEMENTS)	AUDIO CUE	TRANSITION OUT
0:00-0:04	Hook	BG/Miro + kinetic type (hook line)	music in (~110-125 BPM), riser	carry momentum into the problem
0:04-0:12	Problem	the messy status quo; spotlight on the chaos (§15)	low/tense ticks, rumble	match cut into the solution reveal
0:12-0:20	Solution	product UI reveal + logo reveal (draw-on)	hard pause (0.6s) → clean impact	camera push into the walkthrough
0:20-0:44	Walkthrough	the hero: a sticky drops with a squash; the camera zooms out to a vast parallax board	per-action SFX; rising pitch on the hero move	object-continuous cut to benefits
0:44-0:58	Benefits	benefit lines as kinetic type + device/browser mockup (§16)	warm music swell	mockup recedes; proof/logo fades up
0:58-0:64	CTA	draw-on logo lockup + shine sweep + CTA caption	final impact; music resolves	hold ~1.5s, fade to brand BG

⊖ LITMUS

Mute it, run it at 1.5×: does a stranger grasp *Every idea, on one endless canvas the whole team can see.* from the visuals alone? If the hero move, a sticky drops with a squash; the camera zooms out to a vast parallax board, doesn't read silent and sped-up, simplify the frame before you polish the keyframes.

TAKEAWAY

Miro is the same seven-beat skeleton tuned to a expansive, collaborative, kinetic temperature: its kit, its pace, and one forced technique cluster carry the single message, “Every idea, on one endless canvas the whole team can see.”, from hook to CTA.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Real hex codes / fonts verified against the live brand
- ✓ One signature ease applied to every move
- ✓ The hero move reads muted at 1.5×
- ✓ Cuts on downbeats; key action on the stressed syllable
- ✓ Logo animation style matches brand energy



PART III · THE 18 BRAND STUDIES

32 Robinhood

“Investing that fits in your pocket, no jargon required.”, carried end to end: brief, kit, timed script, technique cluster, shot-by-shot timeline, and the assembly note.

SECTIONS

- 32.1 The brief & the angle
- 32.2 Brand kit & pace
- 32.3 The script
- 32.4 Technique cluster & timeline

32.1 The brief & the angle

THE BRIEF

Buyer	B2C
Value prop	Investing made simple and commission-free.
THE single message	"Investing that fits in your pocket, no jargon required."
Angle shift	Beginner: simplicity → Active user: data, options, retirement tools.

32.2 Brand kit & pace

BRAND KIT

Palette	 #00C805 ·  #000000
Background	Black, neon green
Typeface	Capsule Sans → Inter / Capsule
Motion identity	Chart draw-on; counters; sleek dark
Music / BPM	Upbeat consumer · 120-130
VO pace	2.6-2.9 words/sec
Tone words	accessible, sleek, empowering

◆ BRAND NOTE

Regulated product. Carry the real-world disclaimer super at the close, "Investing involves risk, including loss of principal", legible, held long enough to read. The chart draw-on with a riding dot on neon-green-over-black is the hero, but 16-bit + dither is mandatory or the dark gradient bands.

32.3 The script

THE SCRIPT, TIMED, PRODUCTION-READY

[Hook · 0:00-0:04] "Investing felt like a club you weren't invited to."

[Problem · 0:04-0:12] "Fees, jargon, minimums, built to keep regular people out."

[Solution · 0:12-0:20] "Robinhood put the market in your pocket, commission-free."

[Walkthrough · 0:20-0:42] "Search a company you believe in. Buy a slice, even a few dollars' worth. Watch it move, set up recurring buys, and grow on your own terms."

[Benefits · 0:42-0:56] "So investing stops being intimidating and starts being yours."

[CTA · 0:56-0:62] "Start investing. Download free."

32.4 Technique cluster & timeline

What this brand forces: Line-chart draw-on with riding dot (§13), counting numbers (§13), sleek dark depth (§16), phone mockup (§22), search/buy flow, the required risk disclaimer super.

SHOT-BY-SHOT TIMELINE, ROBINHOOD

TC	BEAT	ON-SCREEN (ELEMENTS)	AUDIO CUE	TRANSITION OUT
0:00-0:04	Hook	BG/ Robinhood + kinetic type (hook line)	music in (~120-130 BPM), riser	carry momentum into the problem
0:04-0:12	Problem	the messy status quo; spotlight on the chaos (§15)	low/tense ticks, rumble	match cut into the solution reveal
0:12-0:20	Solution	product UI reveal + logo reveal (draw-on)	hard pause (0.6s) → clean impact	camera push into the walkthrough
0:20-0:42	Walkthrough	the hero: a search, a one-tap buy, a chart draws on with a riding dot, risk super held	per-action SFX; rising pitch on the hero move	object-continuous cut to benefits
0:42-0:56	Benefits	benefit lines as kinetic type + device/ browser mockup (§16)	warm music swell	mockup recedes; proof/logo fades up
0:56-0:62	CTA	draw-on logo lockup + shine sweep + CTA caption	final impact; music resolves	hold ~1.5s, fade to brand BG

⊖ LITMUS

Mute it, run it at 1.5×: does a stranger grasp *Investing that fits in your pocket, no jargon required.* from the visuals alone? If the hero move, a search, a one-tap buy, a chart draws on with a riding dot, risk super held, doesn't read silent and sped-up, simplify the frame before you polish the keyframes.

TAKEAWAY

Robinhood is the same seven-beat skeleton tuned to a accessible, sleek, empowering temperature: its kit, its pace, and one forced technique cluster carry the single message, “Investing that fits in your pocket, no jargon required.”, from hook to CTA.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Real hex codes / fonts verified against the live brand
- ✓ One signature ease applied to every move
- ✓ The hero move reads muted at 1.5×
- ✓ Cuts on downbeats; key action on the stressed syllable
- ✓ Risk disclaimer super present and legible



PART III · THE 18 BRAND STUDIES

33 Headspace

“A few minutes to feel less stressed today.”, carried end to end: brief, kit, timed script, technique cluster, shot-by-shot timeline, and the assembly note.

SECTIONS

- 33.1 The brief & the angle
- 33.2 Brand kit & pace
- 33.3 The script
- 33.4 Technique cluster & timeline

33.1 The brief & the angle

THE BRIEF

Buyer	B2C + B2B (benefits)
Value prop	Guided meditation for a calmer mind.
THE single message	"A few minutes to feel less stressed today."
Angle shift	Individual: calm / sleep → Employer: workforce wellbeing & lower burnout.

33.2 Brand kit & pace

BRAND KIT

Palette	 #FF7E1D ·  #FFC400
Background	Warm gradient washes
Typeface	Apercu / HS Sans → Poppins / Apercu
Motion identity	Slow drift; organic blobs; soft glow
Music / BPM	Calm / ambient · 60-80 (beatless)
VO pace	2.0 words/sec
Tone words	soft, unhurried, warm

◆ BRAND NOTE

The slowest video in the book, ~2.0 words/sec, long pauses, beatless ambient bed. Motion is drift and breath, never transit. The whole craft is the gradient-blob ambient loop and a barely-perceptible camera push; if anything snaps, it's wrong for this brand.

33.3 The script

THE SCRIPT, TIMED, PRODUCTION-READY

[Hook · 0:00-0:05] "Take a breath. No, really, one slow breath."

[Problem · 0:05-0:13] "Your mind's been running all day. It hasn't had a moment to land."

[Solution · 0:13-0:22] "Headspace gives it that moment, guided, simple, just a few minutes."

[Walkthrough · 0:22-0:46] "Pick how you feel. Press play. A calm voice walks you through it. And when the day won't switch off, a sleepcast eases you down."

[Benefits · 0:46-0:60] "So you end the day a little lighter than you started it."

[CTA · 0:60-0:66] "Feel calmer. Try Headspace free."

33.4 Technique cluster & timeline

What this brand forces: Ambient gradient-blob loop (§16 loopOut pingpong), soft glow, slow camera drift (§14), breathing-scale loops, organic illustration (§10). Deliberately *no* transit/pulse motion.

SHOT-BY-SHOT TIMELINE, HEADSPACE

TC	BEAT	ON-SCREEN (ELEMENTS)	AUDIO CUE	TRANSITION OUT
0:00-0:05	Hook	BG/ Headspace + kinetic type (hook line)	music in (~60-80 BPM), riser	carry momentum into the problem
0:05-0:13	Problem	the messy status quo; spotlight on the chaos (§15)	low/tense ticks, rumble	match cut into the solution reveal
0:13-0:22	Solution	product UI reveal + logo reveal (draw-on)	hard pause (0.6s) → clean impact	camera push into the walkthrough
0:22-0:46	Walkthrough	the hero: gradient blobs drift; a calm session plays; a sleepcast eases down	per-action SFX; rising pitch on the hero move	object-continuous cut to benefits
0:46-0:60	Benefits	benefit lines as kinetic type + device/browser mockup (§16)	warm music swell	mockup recedes; proof/logo fades up
0:60-0:66	CTA	draw-on logo lockup + shine sweep + CTA caption	final impact; music resolves	hold ~1.5s, fade to brand BG

⊖ LITMUS

Mute it, run it at 1.5×: does a stranger grasp *A few minutes to feel less stressed today.* from the visuals alone? If the hero move, gradient blobs drift; a calm session plays; a sleepcast eases down, doesn't read silent and sped-up, simplify the frame before you polish the keyframes.

TAKEAWAY

Headspace is the same seven-beat skeleton tuned to a soft, unhurried, warm temperature: its kit, its pace, and one forced technique cluster carry the single message, “A few minutes to feel less stressed today.”, from hook to CTA.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Real hex codes / fonts verified against the live brand
- ✓ One signature ease applied to every move
- ✓ The hero move reads muted at 1.5×
- ✓ Cuts on downbeats; key action on the stressed syllable
- ✓ Logo animation style matches brand energy



PART III • THE 18 BRAND STUDIES

34 HubSpot

“Stop stitching tools together, grow on one connected platform.”, carried end to end: brief, kit, timed script, technique cluster, shot-by-shot timeline, and the assembly note.

SECTIONS

- 34.1 The brief & the angle
- 34.2 Brand kit & pace
- 34.3 The script
- 34.4 Technique cluster & timeline

34.1 The brief & the angle

THE BRIEF

Buyer	B2B
Value prop	One platform for marketing, sales, and service.
THE single message	"Stop stitching tools together, grow on one connected platform."
Angle shift	SMB: free CRM start → Enterprise: full revenue platform with attribution.

34.2 Brand kit & pace

BRAND KIT

Palette	 #FF7A59 ·  #00BDA5
Background	White / navy #33475B
Typeface	Lexend Deca → Lexend
Motion identity	Pipeline flows; funnel viz; connected
Music / BPM	Confident tech · 100-120
VO pace	2.4-2.6 words/sec
Tone words	connected, clear, growth-minded

◆ BRAND NOTE

HubSpot is the warm, busy cousin of the Stripe flow: multiple lanes moving at once, a single contact record visibly traveling marketing → sales → service and changing state-color at each node. The "one connected platform" idea made literal.

34.3 The script

THE SCRIPT, TIMED, PRODUCTION-READY

[Hook · 0:00-0:04] "Five tools that don't talk to each other. Sound familiar?"

[Problem · 0:04-0:13] "Marketing, sales, and support each have their own software, and your customer falls through the cracks between them."

[Solution · 0:13-0:22] "HubSpot puts all three on one connected platform."

[Walkthrough · 0:22-0:48] "A lead comes in through marketing, flows straight to sales, and support sees the whole history. One contact record, one timeline, every team aligned."

[Benefits · 0:48-0:62] "So nothing slips through, and growth stops being a guessing game."

[CTA · 0:62-0:68] "Grow better. Start free with HubSpot CRM."

34.4 Technique cluster & timeline

What this brand forces: Pipeline flow (§13.4 multi-lane variant), funnel viz, the single contact record traveling stages, counting numbers (§13), connected-platform diagram, orange-to-teal.

SHOT-BY-SHOT TIMELINE, HUBSPOT

TC	BEAT	ON-SCREEN (ELEMENTS)	AUDIO CUE	TRANSITION OUT
0:00-0:04	Hook	BG/ HubSpot + kinetic type (hook line)	music in (~100-120 BPM), riser	carry momentum into the problem
0:04-0:13	Problem	the messy status quo; spotlight on the chaos (§15)	low/tense ticks, rumble	match cut into the solution reveal
0:13-0:22	Solution	product UI reveal + logo reveal (draw-on)	hard pause (0.6s) → clean impact	camera push into the walkthrough
0:22-0:48	Walkthrough	the hero: one contact record travels marketing → sales → service, recoloring at each node	per-action SFX; rising pitch on the hero move	object-continuous cut to benefits
0:48-0:62	Benefits	benefit lines as kinetic type + device/ browser mockup (§16)	warm music swell	mockup recedes; proof/logo fades up
0:62-0:68	CTA	draw-on logo lockup + shine sweep + CTA caption	final impact; music resolves	hold ~1.5s, fade to brand BG

⊖ LITMUS

Mute it, run it at 1.5×: does a stranger grasp *Stop stitching tools together, grow on one connected platform.* from the visuals alone? If the hero move, one contact record travels marketing → sales → service, recoloring at each node, doesn't read silent and sped-up, simplify the frame before you polish the keyframes.

TAKEAWAY

HubSpot is the same seven-beat skeleton tuned to a connected, clear, growth-minded temperature: its kit, its pace, and one forced technique cluster carry the single message, "Stop stitching tools together, grow on one connected platform.", from hook to CTA.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Real hex codes / fonts verified against the live brand
- ✓ One signature ease applied to every move
- ✓ The hero move reads muted at 1.5×
- ✓ Cuts on downbeats; key action on the stressed syllable
- ✓ Logo animation style matches brand energy



PART IV

Apply It to Any SaaS

The method generalises. Here it is proven on a product that wasn't in the original eighteen and doesn't exist at all, an invented project-analytics tool carried end-to-end exactly like the brand studies.



IN THIS PART

- 35 The Intake-to-Delivery Framework
- 36 Full Worked Example, 'Cadence'



PART IV • APPLY IT TO ANY SAAS

35 The Intake-to-Delivery Framework

A repeatable path for a brand you have never animated: research, extract the brand system, choose the angle, script, pre-viz, build, deliver. The same seven steps every time.

SECTIONS

- 35.1 Research & extract
- 35.2 Choose the angle
- 35.3 Script & pre-viz
- 35.4 Build & deliver

Everything in Parts I-III was the system; this is the checklist for pointing it at anything. Run it top to bottom and a brand you saw for the first time this morning is in production tonight.

35.1 Research & extract the brand system

► BUILD IT, EXTRACT THE SYSTEM

1. **Pull the real kit.** Visit the live product and its brand/press page; lift the actual hex codes, fonts (or the closest free substitute), corner radii, and shadow style. Screenshot the real UI at 2×.
2. **Name the motion identity.** Watch their existing videos and site interactions; write the one-line motion signature ("fast snap cuts," "slow drift," "bouncy pops") and pick the signature ease.
3. **Three tone words.** The arbiter for every later judgment call (Chapter 4).

35.2 Choose the angle

Run Chapter 2: name the buyer, the one-sentence value prop, and THE single message. Then decide the doorway, B2B clarity or B2C energy, and note how the hook, proof, and CTA would shift for the other audience. Same kit, different door.

35.3 Script & pre-viz

Drop the message into the seven-beat skeleton (Chapter 3), budget words at the brand's pace (Chapter 5), then mood-board, style-frame, storyboard, and cut an animatic (Chapter 4). **Do not animate until the animatic passes muted at 1.5×.**

35.4 Build & deliver

Assign Part II elements per beat, set up the Brand Controls null and saved eases (Chapter 7), build each scene comp, then stitch, score, and polish (Chapter 37) and deliver in every ratio (Chapter 38). Because the elements are parametrized, most of the build is recoloring and retiming, not inventing.

STEP	OUTPUT	CHAPTER
1 · Research & extract	Brand kit + motion signature + 3 tone words	7, 4
2 · Choose the angle	Buyer, value prop, single message, angle shift	2
3 · Script	Timed seven-beat script at brand pace	3, 5
4 · Pre-viz	Mood board, style frames, storyboard, animatic	4
5 · Build	Scene comps from the parametrized library	6, 10-16
6 · Assemble	Stitched master, audio-locked, polished	37, 6
7 · Deliver	ProRes master + re-comped cutdowns + reel	38, 39

TAKEAWAY

Seven steps, every time: extract the system, choose the angle, script, pre-viz, build, assemble, deliver. The framework is brand-agnostic on purpose, the next chapter proves it on a product that doesn't exist.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Real kit extracted from the live brand
- ✓ Single message + angle locked
- ✓ Script timed at the brand's pace
- ✓ Animatic passed muted-1.5× before animating
- ✓ Build is recolor/retime, not invent
- ✓ Delivered in 16:9 / 9:16 / 1:1 + reel cut



PART IV · APPLY IT TO ANY SAAS

36 Full Worked Example, 'Cadence'

An invented project-analytics SaaS, carried end-to-end exactly like the eighteen, proving the system isn't brand-bound. Cadence shows your team's real delivery rhythm so you can see a slip before it happens.

SECTIONS

- 36.1 Invented brief
- 36.2 Brand kit (invented)
- 36.3 The script
- 36.4 Cluster & timeline

◆ BRAND NOTE

Cadence is fictional. It is invented for this chapter to prove the method generalises to a product with no existing brand to copy. Any resemblance to a real company is coincidental; the kit below was designed from scratch using the rules in Chapter 7.

36.1 The invented brief

THE BRIEF

Product	Cadence , project-analytics for software teams
Buyer	B2B (engineering leaders + delivery managers)
Value prop	See your team's real delivery rhythm, so slips show up before they happen.
THE single message	"Know you're going to miss the date, while there's still time to fix it."
Angle shift	IC lead: velocity insight without surveillance → VP Eng: portfolio-level delivery confidence and forecast.

36.2 Brand kit (designed from scratch)

BRAND KIT

Palette	 #3B5BFF signal blue ·  #12B981 on-track green ·  #F59E0B at-risk amber
Background	Near-white #FAFBFD ; a dark dashboard mode #0B1020
Typeface	Inter (UI) + a mono for metrics (JetBrains Mono)
Motion identity	Calm, data-led; lines draw on, pulses flow forward, no bounce
Music / BPM	Confident tech · 105-115 BPM
VO pace	2.4-2.6 words/sec (confident / standard SaaS)
Tone words	clear-eyed, calm, trustworthy

Notice the palette does real work: the green/amber pair is the product's core idea (on-track vs. at-risk), so color carries meaning, not just brand, exactly the discipline from Chapter 7.

36.3 The script

THE SCRIPT, TIMED (78S MASTER)

[Hook · 0:00-0:04] "Every team thinks it'll hit the date. Most find out too late that it won't."

[Problem · 0:04-0:14] "Status updates say "green." The burndown lies. The slip only shows up the week it lands on you."

[Solution · 0:14-0:22] "Cadence reads your team's real delivery rhythm, and flags the slip while you can still move."

[Walkthrough · 0:22-0:50] "Connect your tracker. Watch each workstream draw its real pace. A lane drifts amber, and Cadence shows why, scope crept here, review stalled there. Re-plan, and the forecast updates live."

[Benefits · 0:50-0:64] "So "on track" means something, and the hard conversation happens this week, not at the deadline."

[Proof · 0:64-0:70] "Trusted by delivery teams shipping thousands of issues a month."

[CTA · 0:70-0:78] "See your real cadence. Start free."

36.4 Technique cluster & timeline

What Cadence forces: line-chart draw-on with a riding dot (§13.2), the traveling-pulse pipeline variant for workstreams (§13.4), state-color change at nodes (green→amber), counting forecast numbers (§13.1), a dark-mode dashboard card stack (§15), and a clean reveal-mask logo (§16). No bounce, the tone is clear-eyed and calm.

SHOT-BY-SHOT TIMELINE, CADENCE (INVENTED)

TC	BEAT	ON-SCREEN (ELEMENTS)	AUDIO CUE	TRANSITION OUT
0:00-0:04	Hook	BG/ Cadence dark; kinetic type "hit the date"; a calendar date ticking closer	music in (~110 BPM), riser	date flips red → into the problem
0:04-0:14	Problem	a falsely-flat "green" status card; behind it a real burndown veering off; spotlight (§15)	tense ticks, low rumble	the burndown line becomes the next scene's chart (match cut)
0:14-0:22	Solution	Cadence dashboard reveal; reveal-mask logo on the hard pause	hard pause (0.6s) → clean impact	camera push into the dashboard
0:22-0:50	Walk	workstream lines draw on (§13.2); one lane drifts amber; a pipeline pulse	per-action SFX; rising pitch on the draw	object-continuous cut to benefits

TC	BEAT	ON-SCREEN (ELEMENTS)	AUDIO CUE	TRANSITION OUT
		shows the cause; forecast counter re-settles (§13.1)		
0:50-0:64	Benefits	two benefit lines as kinetic type over a calm dashboard; browser mockup (§16)	warm music swell	mockup recedes; proof fades up
0:64-0:70	Proof	a counting number (issues/month) + a restrained logo row	subtle swell	resolves toward center
0:70-0:78	CTA	Cadence reveal-mask wordmark + shine; "Start free" caption	final impact; music resolves	hold ~1.5s, fade to brand BG

★ PRO MOVE

The amber-drift beat is the whole film: it is the single moment that proves the product's promise ("see the slip while you can still move"). Spend your craft budget there, the state-color change, the cause callout, and the live forecast re-settle, and let everything else stay calm around it.

⊖ LITMUS

Mute it at 1.5x: does a stranger see a healthy plan quietly go at-risk, and the tool catch it in time? If the green→amber turn doesn't read silent, the product's entire value proposition is invisible. That one transition has to survive the test.

TAKEAWAY

Cadence never existed before this page, yet the exact same pipeline, extract a kit, lock a message, script the seven beats, assign the codex elements, time the shots, produces an agency-grade film. The system is the asset, not any one brand.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Kit designed from Chapter 7 rules; color carries meaning
- ✓ Single message + angle locked
- ✓ Script timed at confident-SaaS pace
- ✓ Hero beat (green→amber) reads muted at 1.5×
- ✓ Built from parametrized library elements
- ✓ Fiction clearly labeled; no real-brand implication



PART V

Ship & Sell

From finished film to paid work. The payoff, assembling the flagship end to end, then rendering for every platform, packaging a reel that sells your range, and the pass/fail rubric that keeps it honest.



IN THIS PART

- 37 Final Assembly Walkthrough
- 38 Render & Delivery
- 39 Portfolio & Client Persuasion
- 40 QA Rubric & the Amateur Tells



PART V • SHIP & SELL

37 Final Assembly Walkthrough

The proof that the playbook composes. Take the script, the kit, the elements, and the timeline, and assemble the finished 80-second Stripe explainer, not new work, the stack coming together.

SECTIONS

- 37.1 Project skeleton
- 37.2 Scene comps
- 37.3 Stitching the master
- 37.4 Audio & the polish pass

If Parts I-IV were done well, assembly is almost mechanical: stack labeled scene comps in order, stitch with momentum-carrying transitions, lock audio to beats and stressed syllables, and run one polish pass.

37.1 Step 0, project skeleton

► BUILD IT, THE SKELETON FIRST

1. New project, 16-bit, sRGB. Duplicate the folder template (`00_COMPS` ... `03_BRAND`).
2. Build the **Brand Controls** null: Primary `#635BFF` , Dark `#0A2540` , gradient stops. Save Stripe type presets and the “**Stripe_smooth**” ease (80/20, no overshoot).
3. Build `BG/Stripe_gradient` : angled multi-stop gradient (16-bit + 1% noise), slow phase drift. It sits under every scene.
4. Create the master comp `00_STRIPE_MASTER` 1920×1080 / 30 fps / 80 s.

37.2 Step 1, build the eight scene comps

SCENE COMP	BUILT FROM (PART II)
<code>01_Hook</code>	BG gradient + kinetic “3 months” (tracking-expand §11) + calendar-page icons flying off (§12)
<code>02_Problem</code>	integration-logo icon cards toppling, spotlight (§15); logos collapse → brackets
<code>03_Solution</code>	code-editor UI card (§10) + Stripe logo draw-on (§16) on the hard pause; push-in
<code>04_Walk_Code</code>	typing UI types the <code>charges.create</code> call; a <code>POST</code> line glows, emits the packet
<code>05_Walk_Flow</code>	connection lines + network nodes + traveling pulse (§13.4), the centerpiece; camera follows the packet
<code>06_Walk_Dashboard</code>	UI card stack (§15) + counting revenue (§13.1) + line chart draw-on with riding dot; parallax tilt
<code>07_Benefits</code>	browser mockup (§16) + two kinetic-type benefit lines (§11)
<code>08_Proof_CTA</code>	logo grid staggered (§15) + counting number + wordmark draw-on + shine; CTA caption

Each scene comp is fully animated and self-contained, judged at playback speed and at 50% zoom *before* it goes into the master.

37.3 Step 2, stitch the master

Drop the eight comps on the master in order, **overlapping each by 6-8 frames** (never hard-cut-to-black). A single global `BG/Stripe_gradient` runs continuously beneath all scenes so the background never cuts. The seams that make it feel like one film:

- Hook→Problem: the shattered “3 months” pieces become the toppling logos (carry momentum).
- Problem→Solution: logos collapse into `{ }` brackets, **match cut**, brackets present in both scenes at the same place/scale.

- Solution→Walk_Code: continuous camera push straight through the cut.
- Walk_Code→Walk_Flow: the packet launched in Code is the same packet that travels in Flow, **the object is continuous across the cut** (the strongest stitch in the film).
- Walk_Flow→Dashboard: the “Settled” node scales up to become the dashboard (scale reveal).
- Dashboard→Benefits: dashboard scales down into the browser mockup.
- Benefits→Proof→CTA: mockup recedes in Z; logo wall fades up; grid resolves to the wordmark.

37.4 Steps 3-4, audio & the polish pass

● ANIMATE IT, LOCK AUDIO, THEN POLISH

1. Lay the 110 BPM bed; markers every 15 frames; nudge each scene's in-point onto a downbeat.
2. Import the VO (-16 LUFS), mark stressed syllables, confirm each key action lands on its marker, “set-tle” hits the success pulse in 05_Walk_Flow.
3. Place SFX (typing, rising-pitch-along-line + ding, counter-rise, the logo impact + shine); duck music -5 dB under VO.
4. **Polish:** global motion blur on; consistency sweep for stray linear keyframes; one adjustment layer (gentle Curves contrast + 2% vignette + faint grain); confirm ~0.4 s of VO silence before the CTA.

🕒 LITMUS

The last gate before render: zoom the timeline to 50%, mute, and play at 1.5×. Every beat must still read , a hook that names the pain, a problem you feel, a clean reveal, code becoming a packet that flows and settles, a living dashboard, outcomes, fast proof, and a CTA that draws on and shines. Fix any beat that doesn't.

TAKEAWAY

Assembly is stacking labeled scene comps in order, stitching with momentum-carrying transitions, locking audio to beats and stressed syllables, and one polish pass, and the exact same procedure produces the other seventeen.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Brand skeleton built first
- ✓ Each scene comp approved solo (playback + 50%)
- ✓ Scenes overlap; object-continuous match cuts placed
- ✓ Cuts on downbeats; actions on stressed syllables
- ✓ Global motion blur + adjustment-layer polish
- ✓ Final muted-1.5× pass passes



PART V · SHIP & SELL

38 Render & Delivery

Master in ProRes, deliver in H.264 at a bitrate high enough to protect gradients, and re-comp, don't crop, each aspect ratio with burned-in captions for sound-off feeds.

SECTIONS

- 38.1 Master export
- 38.2 Aspect-ratio cutdowns
- 38.3 Platform specs

38.1 Master export

- **Route:** `Composition > Add to Adobe Media Encoder Queue`, don't render H.264 from AE directly.
- **Delivery codec:** H.264 MP4, VBR 2-pass, **16-24 Mbps** at 1080p (higher for gradient-heavy Stripe/Headspace). 4K master: 40-50 Mbps.
- **Audio:** AAC 320 kbps, 48 kHz, **-16 LUFS integrated, -1 dBTP**.
- **Archive master:** also export **ProRes 422 HQ** as the mezzanine, re-encode platform versions from this, never from the compressed MP4.

38.2 Aspect-ratio cutdowns

Don't just crop, **re-comp** so hierarchy survives.

FORMAT	SIZE	HOW TO BUILD	WHAT CHANGES
16:9 master	1920×1080	source of truth	,
9:16 vertical	1080×1920	nest master scenes, scale UI up ~140%, re-stack vertically, enlarge text	UI bigger; layouts vertical; captions burned in
1:1 square	1080×1080	center-crop, lift the focal element, re-position text to top/bottom thirds	tighter framing; trim to ~30-45s

Use Essential Graphics / responsive design or duplicate-and-reframe. Burn captions on vertical/square (sound-off default). Keep the logo lockup and CTA equally legible in all three.

38.3 Platform specs (quick reference)

- **YouTube:** 1080p/4K, 16:9, H.264, up to 24 Mbps.
- **Instagram / TikTok Reels:** 1080×1920 9:16, ≤60s in-feed, captions on, ≤30 Mbps.
- **LinkedIn (B2B sweet spot):** 1:1 or 16:9, aim ≤90s, captions essential.
- **Website hero / autoplay loop:** a muted, seamless-loop H.264 (+ WebM/VP9 fallback), ~10-20s.
- **X / Twitter:** 16:9 or 1:1, ≤2:20, captions on.

TAKEAWAY

Master in ProRes, deliver in H.264 at a bitrate that protects gradients, and re-comp (don't crop) each ratio with burned-in captions for the muted feeds that dominate distribution.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ ProRes mezzanine archived
- ✓ H.264 bitrate protects gradients
- ✓ Audio -16 LUFS / -1 dBTP
- ✓ 9:16 & 1:1 re-comped, not cropped
- ✓ Captions burned on vertical/square
- ✓ Per-platform versions exported



PART V · SHIP & SELL

39 Portfolio & Client Persuasion

Sell the thinking and the outcome, not the keyframes. Show your process, tailor the pitch to B2B clarity versus B2C energy, and let the reel prove range in sixty seconds.

SECTIONS

- 39.1 Package the eighteen
- 39.2 B2B vs B2C buyers
- 39.3 Present so it converts

39.1 Package the eighteen into a reel + case studies

- **The reel (60-90s):** the best 2-3s of each video, cut to one driving track, fastest hooks first. The top-of-page hero, it sells your range and rhythm in under a minute. Lead with your three strongest (e.g. Stripe, Spotify, Linear).
- **Case-study page per flagship (3-5):** show the *thinking*. Brief → single message → 1-2 style frames → storyboard → finished video → one craft detail ("how the packet travels the network"). Buyers hire the thinking.
- **Before/after & process clips:** a 10s "animatic → final" split builds huge trust, it proves you have a process, the #1 thing separating a hireable pro from a hobbyist.

39.2 What B2B vs B2C buyers respond to

	B2B BUYER	B2C BUYER
Wants to see	Clarity, restraint, "you made the complex simple," real UI handled well	Energy, brand personality, emotional hook, scroll-stopping first 3s
Proof that lands	Process rigor, on-brand discipline, the message landed muted	Aesthetic range, motion craft, vibe match
Pitch framing	"I reduce time-to-understanding for complex products."	"I make your brand impossible to scroll past."
Format priority	16:9 + 1:1 for LinkedIn; case studies	9:16 Reels/TikTok; the reel

39.3 Present so the work converts

- **Open with outcome, not craft:** "This explainer cut their demo-request friction" beats "I used Trim Paths."
- **Show you understood *their* single message,** reference their real positioning in the first email. It signals you do Chapter 2 before you touch AE.
- **One reel, three case studies, a one-line rate/process** on the page. Don't bury the contact.
- **Spec pieces are fine,** label them "concept" so there's no false-endorsement claim; your whole eighteen-piece set proves you can nail a known brand's system.

TAKEAWAY

Sell the thinking and the outcome, not the keyframes, show your process (animatic → final), tailor the pitch to B2B clarity vs B2C energy, and let the reel prove range in sixty seconds.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ 60-90s reel, strongest hooks first
- ✓ 3-5 case studies showing process
- ✓ Animatic → final clip
- ✓ Pitch framed around the buyer's outcome
- ✓ Spec work clearly labeled "concept"
- ✓ Contact / rate visible



PART V • SHIP & SELL

40 QA Rubric & the Amateur Tells

The pass/fail review you run before every delivery, and the fifteen mistakes that read as amateur, with the four that matter most. Nail those four and the work jumps a tier instantly.

SECTIONS

- 40.1 The pass/fail rubric
- 40.2 The fifteen tells
- 40.3 The four that matter most

40.1 The pass/fail rubric

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ **Story:** hook lands the tension in ≤ 3 s; problem before solution; one message per scene; CTA is a single clear action; whole video readable muted at 1.5 $\times$.
- ✓ **Motion:** every move uses the brand's one signature ease (no stray linear keyframes); shots 2-5s; staggered entrances; motion encodes cause $\rightarrow$ effect; motion blur on for fast moves.
- ✓ **Design:** real hex/fonts verified; hierarchy survives at 50% zoom; text readable in 1-2s; gradients banding-free (16-bit + dither); consistent spacing.
- ✓ **Audio:** cuts on downbeats, key actions on stressed syllables; VO -16 LUFS with music ducked under; designed moment-sound on the reveal + logo.
- ✓ **Delivery:** ProRes archived; H.264 bitrate protects gradients; 9:16 + 1:1 re-comped with burned captions; disclaimer supers where required (Robinhood).

40.2 The fifteen tells

#	AMATEUR TELL	#	AMATEUR TELL
1	Linear easing everywhere (the #1 tell)	9	Text too small / on too briefly to read
2	No stagger, all on the same frame	10	Mixed transition vocabulary every cut
3	Flat fades instead of motion	11	Over-animated logo for a serious brand
4	One hard drop shadow, not layered soft ones	12	Atmosphere louder than content
5	8-bit gradient banding on dark BGs	13	Music ignored; cuts off the beat
6	Real-time, full-screen, uncropped recordings	14	No problem beat, features with no tension
7	Robotic cursors, straight, instant clicks	15	Animating before the animatic passes
8	Too much on screen; no single focal point		

40.3 The four that matter most

★ PRO MOVE

Most "amateur" verdicts trace to four fixable things: **linear easing, no stagger, gradient banding, and uncropped recordings**. Nail easing, sequencing, 16-bit gradients, and framed/cropped footage and the work jumps a tier before you touch anything else. Fix these first, every time.

⊖ LITMUS

The rubric's master line, one last time: *can someone understand this muted, at 1.5 $\times$?* Applied ruthlessly, on every scene, every brand, every delivery, it is the entire difference between tutorial output and agency output.

TAKEAWAY

Run the full pass/fail list before every delivery; most failures are four fixable things. Nail easing, sequencing, 16-bit gradients, and framed footage, hold every scene to the muted 1.5× test, and the work is agency-grade by definition.

How the chapters chain: 1-2 pick and write the message • 3-9 set voice, sound, brand, and the rulebook • 10-16 build the reusable parts • 17-36 apply the whole stack to eighteen brands and one invented proof • 37-40 ship it and keep it honest. Do them in order, build the Part II library once, and each video becomes assembly rather than invention.



PART ,

Reference

Everything you reach for mid-build, collected: every expression, the keyboard shortcuts, the plugin directory with free fallbacks, asset sourcing, a tear-out QA rubric, copyable templates, a plain-language glossary, and the colophon.



IN THIS PART

- A Expression Library
- B AE Keyboard Shortcuts
- C Plugin & Tool Directory
- D Asset Sourcing
- E QA Rubric (tear-out)
- F Reusable Templates
- , Glossary, Index & Colophon

APPENDIX A

A Expression Library

Every expression in the book, collected and fully written, with usage notes. Paste onto the named property; drive the inputs with a Brand Controls null and slider controls so one master recolors and retimes many instances.

A.1 • COUNTING NUMBER WITH THOUSANDS COMMAS (SOURCE TEXT)

```
// Slider "Count" keyframed 0 -> target, ease-out (~1s, not >1.2s).
n = effect("Count")("Slider");
"$" + n.toFixed(0).replace(/\B(?=(\d{3})+(?!\d))/g, ",");
```

A.2 • NODE-ARRIVAL PULSE, NO KEYFRAMES (TARGET NODE SCALE)

```
// Drop a layer marker named "hit" where the packet lands.
m = thisLayer.marker.key("hit").time;
d = time - m;
amp = (d >= 0 && d < 0.4) ? Math.sin(d / 0.4 * Math.PI) * 15 : 0;
[100 + amp, 100 + amp];
```

A.3 • AUTO-STAGGER A NETWORK (EACH LINE'S TRIM END)

```
// All lines share one keyframed master; index offsets each by ~4 frames.
off = (index - 1) * 4 * thisComp.frameDuration;
master = thisComp.layer("Pulse_Master");
master.content("Trim Paths 1").end.valueAtTime(time - off);
```

A.4 • BEAT-DRIVEN SCALE (PICKWHIP TO AUDIO AMPLITUDE)

```
s = thisComp.layer("Audio Amplitude").effect("Both Channels")("Slider");
[100 + s*0.4, 100 + s*0.4]; // logo/waveform breathes with the kick
```

A.5 • CARET BLINK (CARET OPACITY)

```
Math.round(time*2) % 2 * 100; // ~2 blinks/sec
```

A.6 • IDLE BREATHING LOOP (CHARACTER TORSO SCALE Y)

```
loopOut("pingpong"); // two keys 100 -> 101 over ~1s; barely perceptible
```

A.7 • AMBIENT FLOAT (CARD POSITION; KEEP TINY)

```
wiggle(0.5, 6); // 0.5/sec, 6px; if you notice it, halve it
```

A.8 • SPINNER (LOADER ARC ROTATION)

```
time * 360; // one revolution per second
```

TAKEAWAY

Eight expressions cover the whole book; everything else is scale, opacity, and position with good easing.

APPENDIX B

B AE Keyboard Shortcuts

The shortcuts that keep the build keyboard-fast. macOS shown; swap **Cmd** for **Ctrl** on Windows.

KEYS	DOES
U	Reveal all keyframed properties on selected layers
UU	Reveal everything modified (incl. expressions)
F9	Easy Ease selected keyframes
Y	Pan-Behind (move anchor without moving the layer)
Cmd+Shift+C	Pre-compose selected layers
Cmd+Alt+Home	Center anchor point in layer content
Alt+] / Alt+[	Trim layer out / in to playhead
* (numpad)	Drop a layer marker (during RAM preview, on the beat)
P / S / R / T / A	Position / Scale / Rotation / Opacity / Anchor
Shift+ +/-	Nudge a keyframe's value (with property selected)
'	Toggle title/action-safe & grid guides
B / N	Set work-area start / end to playhead

APPENDIX C

C Plugin & Tool Directory

Every paid tool has a free fallback, nothing in this book is gated.

PLUGIN	JOB	FREE FALLBACK
Flow	Visual easing-curve editor, saved presets	Graph Editor + Easy Ease (F9)
Motion 4 / Tools Pro	Anchor snapping, rigging, ease shortcuts	Pan-Behind (Y), manual expressions
Overlord	Illustrator → AE vector transfer	<code>.ai</code> import + Create Shapes
GEOlayers / Newton	Maps / 2D physics	Keyframe by hand
Trapcode Particular	Particles, light streaks	CC Particle World (built-in)
Saber (free, Boris FX)	Glow, light streaks, energy lines	Built-in Glow + Fast Box Blur
EaseCopy / Excitebike	Copy easing between keyframes	Manual
Rotato	3D device mockups	Figma device frames / flat mockups

APPENDIX D

D Asset Sourcing

NEED	WHERE	LICENSING NOTE
Music	Artlist, Musicbed, Epidemic Sound	Licensed for portfolio + client use; keep the license PDF
SFX	Epidemic, Soundsnap, freesound (CC)	Check the CC tier; attribute where required
Fonts	Foundry / Adobe Fonts; or free substitutes (Inter, Poppins, Nunito, Lexend, Montserrat)	Use the substitute unless the client licenses the real face
Brand logos	The brand's official press/brand kit (SVG, not PNG)	Spec work only; label "concept"; never imply endorsement
Icons	Lucide, Feather, Phosphor (open); Streamline (paid)	Keep stroke weight consistent across the set
Mockups	Rotato, Figma community device frames	Match the screen mask radius to the device

◆ BRAND NOTE

Legal, restated. Spec/portfolio brand use is fine as clearly-unofficial homage; never imply endorsement. Regulated products (Robinhood) carry the real disclaimer super. Paid client work uses only client-provided or licensed assets.

APPENDIX E

E QA Rubric, tear-out

Run before every delivery. If you fail any *story* item, re-cut, don't polish.

✓ CHECKLIST

- ✓ Hook lands the tension in $\leq 3s$
- ✓ Problem shown before solution
- ✓ One message per scene; CTA a single action
- ✓ Whole video readable muted at 1.5×
- ✓ Every move on the brand's one signature ease (no stray linear)
- ✓ Shots 2-5s; staggered entrances; motion blur on fast moves
- ✓ Motion encodes cause→effect; transitions carry momentum
- ✓ Real hex/fonts verified; hierarchy survives at 50% zoom
- ✓ Gradients 16-bit + dither (no banding)
- ✓ Cuts on downbeats; actions on stressed syllables
- ✓ VO -16 LUFS, music ducked, SFX under music
- ✓ ProRes archived; H.264 protects gradients
- ✓ 9:16 + 1:1 re-comped with burned captions
- ✓ Disclaimer supers where required

APPENDIX F

F Reusable Templates

Storyboard

SHOT	FRAME / LAYOUT	FRAMING	ON SCREEN (NAMED ELEMENTS)	CONNECTS VIA
S__				
S__				
S__				

Shot-by-shot timeline

TC	BEAT	ON-SCREEN	VO LINE	AUDIO	TRANSITION

Asset list

BUILD (PART II)	CAPTURE (RECORDINGS)	SOURCE (LICENSED)

Animatic checklist

✓ CHECKLIST

✓ Muted at 1.5× reads

✓ No dead beats >2.5s

✓ Hook clear by 0:03

✓ VO/visual in sync

✓ Runtime 45-90s

✓ Cuts roughly on downbeats

REFERENCE

, Glossary

TERM	MEANING
Animatic	A timed rough cut of storyboard frames + scratch VO + temp music, used to test pacing before animating.
Brand Controls null	A null object holding one Color Control per brand color; every fill references it, so one change recolors the whole video.
Ease 80/20	Velocity influence 80% out / 20% in, the house “snap out, soft land.”
Easy Ease	AE’s built-in smooth-in/out on keyframes (F9).
LUFS	Loudness Units Full Scale, the integrated-loudness standard; web target -16 LUFS.
Match cut	A transition where a shared shape continues across the cut so the eye reads one object.
Overlapping action	Delaying child parts a few frames behind the parent so motion has lag and life.
Range Selector	A text animator selector that reveals characters by index, the basis of the typing reveal.
Squash-and-stretch	Scale exaggeration that gives a moving object weight and life.
Traveling pulse	Two offset Trim Paths on a glowing copy of a line, racing a short segment down it to show data flowing.
Trim Paths	A shape modifier that draws a stroke on by animating Start/End, the engine behind lines, rings, and check-draws.
16-bit	Project color depth that prevents gradient banding on dark backgrounds; pair with low-opacity noise to dither.

REFERENCE

, Index

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, About the Author & Colophon

LULU directs motion and editorial craft, building agency-grade explainer for software brands and the systems that make them repeatable. This book is the studio's working method, written down.

Colophon. Set in Space Grotesk (display), Inter (text), Spectral (serif & quotes), and JetBrains Mono (code & folios). Composed for A4 print and produced as a single print-ready PDF via an HTML/CSS pipeline (WeasyPrint). The eighteen-brand spectrum motif on the openers and covers maps, in order, to the real primary colors of the eighteen products studied inside. Personal Edition, 2026.

LAST WORD

Same system, eighteen recognizable brands, agency-grade every time, that repeatability is the whole point, and now it is yours.



Most explainer videos die in the same four places: linear easing, no stagger, banded gradients, and raw screen-recordings. This book is the system that fixes all four, and then builds, from scratch in After Effects, eighteen explainers for brands you already know, plus a repeatable method for any product you'll ever be handed.

WHAT YOU'LL LEARN

- , Conceive, script, and pre-viz a video that survives the muted-1.5× test
- , Build one reusable element library: cards, cursors, counters, the traveling pulse
- , Set up any brand's real color, type, and signature ease as AE assets
- , Carry all 18 brands end-to-end, with full shot-by-shot timelines
- , Render, re-comp, and sell the work to B2B and B2C buyers

LULU

LULU Studio Press · Personal Edition, 2026